



We think Scotland has a bright future.

Scottish Liberal Democrats 2007 Manifesto

A vision for Scotland

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Bright future

The past two years have been very good for the Scottish Liberal Democrats. Following the 2005 UK General Election we are stronger than at any time in the last half century. Our share of the vote went up from 16 per cent to over 22 per cent. **We came second in share of the vote and number of seats**, beating the SNP and Conservatives. We won two new constituencies in Inverness, Nairn, Badenoch and Strathspey, and East Dunbartonshire. For the first time, our share of the vote in Scotland's four party system was higher than the Liberal Democrat share across the rest of the UK.

Only the Liberal Democrats have real momentum

Following on from these successes came the stunning Liberal Democrat victory in the Dunfermline and West Fife by-election in February 2006. **We achieved a swing of over 16 per cent to win the seat from Labour.** The gain was all the more remarkable as it was not predicted by the nation's political pundits or media. It emphasised that the Liberal Democrats are the only party with real momentum.

The scale of our progress has also been emphasised by other recent results. In Moray - in circumstances where our vote would traditionally have been squeezed - we saw our vote increase from 12 per cent to 20 per cent, a larger increase than any other party.

In local government we sensationally won the King's Park by-election in Glasgow from fourth place. In the summer we won the Lochardil by-election in Inverness, notably in a Scottish Parliament seat currently held by the SNP.

Winning in new parts of Scotland

To understand our success in Dunfermline you need to analyse some of the new trends in Scottish politics.





Across Scotland, historic loyalties are shifting.

Traditional class and family-based voting patterns are breaking down. People are no longer willing to vote the same way.

Increasingly the Liberal Democrats are winning votes amongst young people and in new parts of Scotland. **Increasingly, when offered the opportunity, people are switching to the Liberal Democrats.**

The party of the future

The Scottish Liberal Democrats are increasingly seen as the party of the future. Other parties spend all their time fighting and name calling. We are determined to fight a positive campaign. **While the other parties fight each other, we will fight for Scotland.** No wonder more and more people are turning to the Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Our opportunity has never been greater. Our experience in government in Scotland since 1999 has significantly increased our strength and credibility. All the evidence of recent elections and current opinion polls points to Liberal Democrats making major gains in May. We are now well-placed to become Scotland's largest party. I will fight this election to become Scotland's First Minister.

Our plan for government

We will campaign on the issues that people in Scotland care about most. We will offer positive solutions, not soundbites.

Our whole programme for government is based fundamentally on the principles of sustainable development. In every section of this manifesto we outline policies to make the links between the health and wellbeing of citizens, sustainable development of the economy, and the best management of our natural heritage to deliver a sustainable Scotland.

Graham Stein,



Getting things done

“Month by month - from Polling Day to Christmas Day - Scottish Liberal Democrats in government in Scotland will take the steps for a bright future for Scotland.

We will bring a pace and a dynamic that will leave the other parties behind and take a great stride forward for Scotland's future.”

Nicol Stephen, Leader of the Scottish Liberal Democrats

In seven months we will have set the foundation for a bright future for Scotland.

It's a time to get things done in Scotland. And it is the first time the Scottish Liberal Democrats have set out how our bold plans and positive policies will be taken through government, month by month by month.

There are lots of parties in this election but only the Scottish Liberal Democrats will get things done in 2007.

In 100 days Labour will still be waiting for their orders from the new leader to be sent from London.

In 100 days the SNP will have just begun their constitutional wrangling with Westminster.

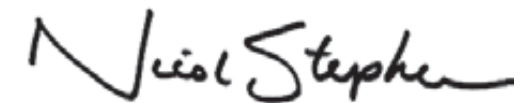
And the Tories have promised they will not go into government and will not implement any of their policies in the first 100 days - or indeed ever.

That will be the choice.

Parties that prefer a bitter battle of words and want to live in the past.

Or the Scottish Liberal Democrats with our eye on the future; to work hard; to listen to people; to listen to young people, to give them hope and courage and opportunity - and to get things done.

That is our challenge for Scotland.



Nicol Stephen
Leader of the Scottish Liberal Democrats

May

Christmas Day - Polling Day - 7 months of action.

- out crime
- better local health care
- action on climate change
- new rights and opportunities for young people
- invest in education
- competitive economy

I will appoint ministers given tough new roles to deliver our priorities:

- Local health care
- Carbon saving and climate change
- Delivery for young people
- Crime reduction

June



I will take to Parliament our Future of Scotland Bill:

- New rights for young people
- Graduate endowment scrapped
- Young opportunity fund for young people to decide on local priorities
- More sport and leisure opportunities

July



I will publish our Sentencing and Crime Reduction Bill:

- More effective, tough community sentences to make criminals work to repay their crimes and stop offending
- Knife crime taken more seriously with maximum 7 year prison terms

August



I will publish our Community Policing Plans:

- Recruit and deploy 1,000 extra community police officers into every local town and community
- Crack down on knife crime

September



I will publish our Scottish Energy Bill:

- New targets for renewable energy including 100% by 2050
- Increased energy efficiency in the public and private sector
- A £200 rebate on local taxes for households that fit micropower

October



I will publish our detailed health plans:

- 100 new and refurbished Community Health Centres so people can get care locally
- Diagnosis and treatment quicker and closer your home
- Extra nurses to get things done

We think it's about getting things done.

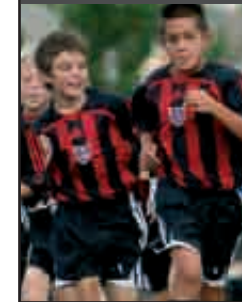
November



I will publish our new business rates for Scotland:

- Set business rates lower than the rest of the UK
- Support for small business
- Create a competitive advantage for Scotland

December



I will publish our plans for education:

- Smaller class sizes and more teacher training places to deliver more teachers and sports coaches
- More powers and support for teachers to tackle discipline

Our priorities for government



Education priorities

- › 250 new and refurbished schools and 1,000 more teachers to cut class sizes.
- › 1 hour of physical activity a day and extra sports coaches.
- › Free playgroup places for 2 year olds.
- › Headteachers to have more powers to turn around poorly performing schools.
- › Tackle poor discipline.



Health priorities

- › 200 extra dentists so everyone has access to an NHS dentist.
- › 100 new and refurbished local health centres.
- › 2,000 extra nurses.
- › Faster diagnosis and treatment with a new waiting time guarantee.
- › Better children's health with free fruit in primary schools and cookery lessons.



Environment priorities

- › 100 per cent renewable electricity with major investment in wave and tidal power.
- › Reduce energy demands with investment in energy efficiency, microgeneration and local power.
- › Reduce waste and increase recycling rates to 70 per cent by 2020.
- › Cut carbon emissions with 4 year targets and annual report.



Economy priorities

- › Lower business rates to below levels in the rest of the UK.
- › Innovation and Investment Agency to deliver threefold increase in business R&D.
- › Cut unnecessary red tape and regulation.
- › More young people into education, training and work with more vocational skills.
- › Invest in further and higher education and scrap the graduate endowment.



Sport, culture and tourism priorities

- › £102 million boost for grassroots sport.
- › Free the arts from excessive government interference.
- › Support for the Scottish Music Futures Fund.
- › Full implementation of the National Gaelic Plan.
- › Grow Scottish tourism by 50 per cent by 2015.





Transport priorities

- › Faster trains between Scotland's cities and support for a high speed link to London.
- › Major new investment in public transport.
- › Make Scotland a cycling nation.
- › Action to improve safety on our roads.
- › Replacement Forth crossing with better public transport.



Young people priorities

- › Schools open at evenings and weekends to offer new activities.
- › Young Opportunity Fund to support youth projects.
- › More outdoor activity and education for young people.
- › Votes at 16.
- › Give young people new rights through a Future of Scotland Bill and youth councils.



Rural priorities

- › New Scottish Food and Drink promotion body.
- › Support more affordable housing through Community Land Trusts.
- › Sustain public services with more co-location and shared services.
- › Increase the use of local Scottish produce across the public sector.
- › Reforesting and biomass.
- › Cut red tape and bureaucracy in agriculture.



Crime and justice priorities

- › 1,000 extra community police officers.
- › Tougher community sentences that make offenders work to repay their crime and cut reoffending.
- › Crack down on knife crime with 7 year maximum sentences.
- › Youth Justice Board and Youth Panels to cut youth crime.
- › Tackle Scotland's drug and alcohol culture.

Governance priorities

- › More powers for the Scottish Parliament.
- › New models of engagement with the public.
- › Governance of Scotland Commission to consider the division of power between central and local government.
- › Second Constitutional Convention to build consensus on new legislative and fiscal powers for the Scottish Parliament.



Communities priorities

- › More affordable housing for sale and rent.
- › Small towns regeneration fund.
- › Scrap council tax and replace with a fairer local income tax based on ability to pay.
- › Support for small independent shops.

Education and young people

“I want an education system that gives all children the best possible start. One that helps children through the change from nursery to primary and across into secondary schools, and doesn’t lose their interest in the first two years of secondary, whether they are high fliers or struggle with the basics.”



I want Scotland to become one of the best places in the world to bring up children. For Scotland to be competitive in the future, we need to invest in our children from the earliest possible age.

Education is the single most important issue for our nation’s future. I believe that we must consider education in its widest sense - not just formal teaching but informal learning, play and exciting opportunities for young people.

Early years education

When I was Deputy Minister for Education, I was proud to deliver the Liberal Democrat pledge of free nursery places for 3 and 4 year olds. It was the right thing to do to give our children the best possible start in life. Today, we have even more evidence that pre-school education makes a real difference to the outcomes of our children’s lives.

Research shows that society sees a return of around £7 for every £1 invested in early years education through improved learning, more advanced communication skills, better health, a more skilled workforce, and less crime. The period up to age six is crucial for a child’s development. So much of their life story is written in those early years.

From the very earliest stage, we should offer help and support to mothers with better screening and support.

We will **pilot the Nurse Family Partnership model** that has had major success in the US in supporting mothers before, during and after pregnancy.

Nursery

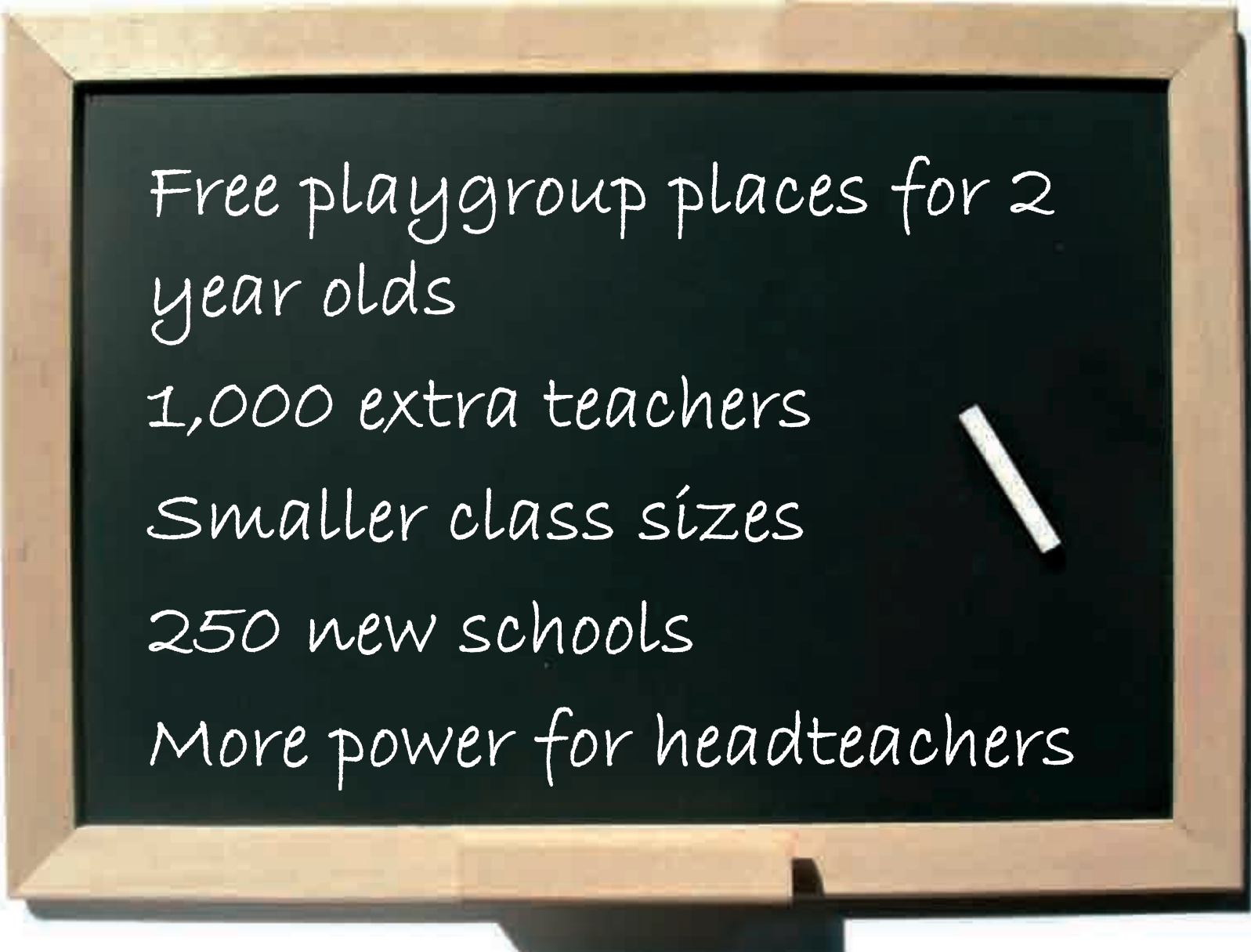
We will build on the hugely successful **free nursery places, extending the entitlement from 33 to 38 weeks** to match the current school year and **to 15 hours per week** to allow time for children to socialise and eat healthy meals together, and make things easier for parents. And we will go further with a **10 year Integrated Early Years and Childcare Strategy** to build capacity and improve training across all parts of the early years workforce, recognising the particularly important role of nursery teachers and nursery nurses.

Learning through play

Research shows that up to one in ten children in the UK and as many as half from disadvantaged areas arrive at primary school with poor speech and language skills. Up to 80 per cent of a child’s language skills are learned by the age of five. I want to introduce a **new Scottish Play Strategy** to highlight the importance of play and communication in a child’s learning and development.

I want to reinvigorate Scotland’s playgroup movement, **doubling the number of playgroups** in Scotland and making them an excellent place for children to start out in life. We will ensure that **every two year old has access to a free place in a local playgroup** for up to 15 hours per week. We will begin a **programme of improvements to early years facilities**, with more greenspace, recognising the **importance of outdoor learning** for all children.





Free playgroup places for 2
year olds

1,000 extra teachers

Smaller class sizes

250 new schools

More power for headteachers



We think there's no more important investment.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Education

Education priorities

- › 250 new schools and 1,000 more teachers to cut class sizes.
- › 1 hour of physical activity a day and extra sports coaches.
- › Free playgroup places for 2 year olds.
- › Headteachers to have more powers to turn around poorly performing schools.
- › Tackle poor discipline.

Transition to primary school

Scotland must learn from those nations that came at the top of the UNICEF index of child wellbeing - particularly the Scandinavian nations. I have visited the Netherlands, Sweden, and Finland - countries ranked 1st, 2nd and 4th in how they treat their young people. I have seen the focus they put on early years education, the investment in the workforce, the high quality facilities, the support for parents, and importantly how children in these countries start their formal schooling a little later.

We will change the way that P1 works to make it a transition year focused on learning through play. This will give teachers more flexibility to introduce children gradually to formal teaching from the age of six. This full-time, teacher-led year will equip children from all backgrounds with the skills they need to make a success of education and allow early support from a wide range of professionals for children who need extra help. There will be greater emphasis on the importance of play and informal learning. In turn this will help primary schools make more progress, more quickly, in subsequent years. It works in other countries, it can work in Scotland.

Support for parents and families

Providing positive support for parents and families as well as quality childcare options is crucial. I want to **increase the support for Sure Start Scotland to expand capacity** and ensure that it can help more families and children. In many cases the real benefits of this investment will not be seen until the long term. For now we will extend the use of early years centres and family centres, and develop a **National Parenting and Family Support Strategy** to help parents to help themselves with more support groups and information.

The financial burden of childcare is significant for many families in Scotland. I want to help reduce that burden. I want to revolutionise the provision of flexible care in schools, both before and after the formal school day. For those parents who do work, and for children looking for

new exciting after school opportunities, we will **extend wraparound care in schools - making high quality, affordable childcare available in schools between 8am and 6pm** for every child whose parents want it.

This will focus on increasing investment in activities for children after the normal school day, including learning, play, sport, art, music, drama and homework clubs. I want this wraparound care to give children in Scotland a rich range of experiences rather than simply being a 'child parking' service.

Children's wellbeing

The recent UNICEF report on children's wellbeing in the UK should be a wake up call for all politicians. It ranked the UK last out of 21 industrialised nations for children's wellbeing - using a number of measures of poverty, education, health and other factors.

I am determined to improve the lives of children and young people in Scotland. That means taking positive action to support children and families at every stage of a child's life.

And it means putting the highest political priority on education in its widest sense. That is why we will begin to **measure the wellbeing of children in Scotland, requiring an annual report** on progress set against that of other nations. And to ensure that the decisions politicians make improve life, we will **introduce Children's Rights Impact Assessment** to show how decisions impact on the rights and wellbeing of children.

Excellent, exciting education

Nothing else has the power of education to inspire individuals and to equip young people to reach their potential. I want an education that looks beyond a narrow range of academic subjects; one that enthuses children about the environment around them; nature, music, art, sport and drama.





We think no child should be left behind.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Education

In short, I want an education for every child that inspires creativity and leadership; confidence as well as knowledge. I want education to be exciting and fun.

Let teachers run schools

Scotland's education has a great reputation across the world. We should never rest in our passion to do more. However, that does not mean heaping further new initiatives on hard-pressed teachers just to get an easy media headline.

Scottish Liberal Democrats are committed to maintaining the comprehensive tradition against moves that would undermine this approach. We want to improve standards in all our schools and help schools and teachers to build on progress - not introduce new institutions like city academies that affect only a tiny minority.

Education has seen major reforms in recent years. I want to keep improving Scottish education, but I know that in order to do that we have to let these new reforms bed in and produce results.

Teachers should run schools not politicians. Great leadership in schools can have a major influence on pupils. I want headteachers to have more powers to develop their schools and give teachers freedom to teach. Where a school wants to develop a specialism or approach that fits their local circumstances they should be encouraged to do just that, without central interference.

I also want to support teachers in the challenges they face daily. I want to improve the support available for headteachers and senior management teams to reduce the burden of paperwork and bureaucracy.

It is important to **give headteachers the powers they need to do their job**. They must be able to act when parents deliberately fail to engage with teachers to resolve problems with their child's learning or behaviour, or where a parent is aggressive towards a teacher. We will **give headteachers new powers to require parents to attend a meeting with the headteacher or education authority**.

Transforming schools

To turn around those schools that are facing challenges in behaviour or attainment I want to **get the best headteachers moving to new schools and fresh challenges every 5 to 7 years**. They can use their skills to transform poorly achieving schools. We will **offer those headteachers new incentives and improved contract terms for this work**. A new **Schools Transformation Fund** will make up to £100,000 available to these headteachers to help turn those schools around.

It is also important that the best teachers are able to teach in those areas or subjects where there are shortages. Whether it is a rural school struggling to find staff, a school that can't fill a long term vacancy, or a school with problems that can't attract the best teachers, it is right to **provide incentives for those individuals who step up to the challenge**.

The best teachers should be allowed to continue in the classroom but their skills should be used to mentor colleagues and improve leadership. We need to continue to increase the flexibility of teaching as a career. Many teachers are considering retiring in the coming years, yet many could continue to play an important role in our schools. We must **extend step-down and part-time opportunities for teachers and do so without adversely affecting their pension and retirement options**. We will use their skills, for example, for one-to-one tutoring for pupils who would benefit from it and mentoring for teachers starting out in their careers.

More teachers, smaller classes, new schools

We already have record teacher numbers in Scotland. I want to increase teacher training places further to **deliver an extra 1,000 teachers above the current record of 53,000**. These extra teachers will be put to good use in **reducing class sizes** and giving more flexibility so that teachers can spend more time developing their skills and knowledge to the benefit of all our children.

These additional teachers will be used to help cut class sizes in P1 to P3 to a maximum of 25 so that our youngest pupils get the personal attention they need. We will work with teachers and local authorities to reduce average class sizes in all primary years. We want local flexibility however, so that national targets don't force local schools into taking decisions that might be detrimental to pupils.

We will **invest in a further 250 new and refurbished schools** to make sure our children and the wider community have access to excellent facilities. We will also improve the design and architecture of new school buildings, learning from the best examples across Europe.

Decisions on the future of local schools are rightly taken by local councillors, accountable to local communities. However there are concerns that in some cases, councils have failed to follow best practice when closing schools. We will use the powers of the Scottish Schools (Parental Involvement) Act to **enable parent councils to ask HMIE to review the decision-making process of the local authority to ensure it has met the requirements of the Scottish Executive guidance on school closures**.

Improving discipline and tackling bullying

Scottish Liberal Democrats support a culture of zero tolerance of violence in the classroom. Abuse of teachers by pupils or parents should be treated far more seriously. Physical, verbal and psychological violence and abuse is not acceptable in our schools.

I want to see all schools implement best practice in promoting positive behaviour, including setting out clear expectations, rules, rewards and sanctions and applying these policies consistently. Pupils themselves should be involved in this process. We will continue to **implement the recommendations of the Better Discipline Taskforce** and seek greater involvement of parents and carers in resolving discipline issues, with **more use of family conferencing** and other innovative techniques. To drive progress still further we will **support the 'Four**





Education

Quid for a Kid' campaign, pledging additional support to tackle bullying.

I want to see more support for teachers to get the latest training in dealing with problem behaviour. And I want to take a **more systematic approach to early intervention from primary level** to ensure pupils who are consistently disruptive are given early attention and tracked through the school system, building on progress.

We will extend the range of services open to schools and local authorities as alternatives to exclusion. When the behaviour of a child continues to threaten teachers and fellow pupils or undermine the educational achievements of the rest of the class we **support the option of exclusion and the use of off-site units.**

Young people themselves want to stamp out bullying. That's why the most effective discipline and anti-bullying strategies will involve pupils directly in drawing up and enforcing them. I want to see **effective peer support and buddying schemes** in every school and more action to ensure that homophobic bullying is taken seriously along with sectarian and racist abuse.

Excellence in the curriculum

Tackling poor discipline is tough. So too is bringing out the best in every pupil, taking the most able to the highest level their talents allow.

Learning and teaching must be flexible enough to adapt to the individual. I want to support teachers in rolling out the new curriculum - a process that will put the priority increasingly on personalised learning, recognising that the old 'age and stage' system does not benefit all children equally.

Children don't always progress in a simple steady way. Our system needs to understand this and act to ensure that every child gets the best out of their time in school.

A system of **personalised learning must become central to the education of every child.** Parents should be far more involved with better, easier to

understand information about each child's progress. At the start of each new year, parents should receive a clear explanation of what his or her child is learning and how best to give support.

We will ensure that **particularly gifted children** have the opportunities they need through peer support groups, summer school, college or university courses, a more stretching curriculum and new or advanced subjects. It's as much a failure of the system not to stretch an academically gifted child as it is to leave a non-academic child behind.

Transition to secondary

I want to see more done to ease the transition between primary and secondary school. We want **all secondary schools to develop transition partnerships with their feeder primary schools,** building on best practice. There should be more opportunities for primary pupils to adapt to secondary education with more introductory visits, secondary teachers visiting primary schools, and the use of coordinators to support children identified as being most at risk of a troubled start to secondary.

Greater communication and follow up between primary and secondary teachers with a nominated member of staff to monitor the child's progress can help to ease the transition. Secondary teachers should spend more time in primary schools to make sure that progress made at primary is built on rather than starting from scratch in secondary.

Skills and knowledge for life

Enterprise education

One of my most important actions was to lead the development of the new enterprise education programme for our schools - Determined to Succeed. It should be only the start in developing a real culture of entrepreneurship.

In 2003 we set a target of 2,000 school-business partnerships. There are now 7,000 across Scotland. **I will raise that to 10,000 by 2010 and increase the involvement of Scotland's business organisations in the future development of enterprise education.**

And because employers constantly tell me of their frustration when recruiting young people about a lack of 'soft skills' - the important skills of communication, teamwork and lateral thinking - I want to see more done in schools to develop these skills from an early age.

Our colleges should work far more closely with our schools. We set out in the Enterprise section of this manifesto our plans for improving vocational skills and training for young people.

Financial skills

The burden of debt in Scotland and the UK is growing. To tackle this spiral of debt, we must look first to education. Children and young people must be equipped with the knowledge and financial skills to see them through life. **I want to see a major push to improve financial education for all children and young people.** Basic financial planning skills must be embedded in the curriculum so that all children better understand financial issues like budgeting, interest, credit, pensions and debt. That means putting personal finance in a social context as well as a mathematical one. **I will support the roll out of more advanced qualifications in financial education.** I will work with banks to make it **easier for young people to open a bank account** with their Young Scot card.

Science

I want to make Scotland a science nation. That's why I want to **increase the support for science in schools and build the links between further and higher education science departments and schools.** We have to make science exciting, sparking a child's imagination with more practical science and increased investment in science facilities.





I want to see **practical science lessons taking place in every primary school**. And to encourage more young people to learn about science we will **make entry to Scotland's science centres free for under 16s**. For Scotland to compete internationally we must do more to support maths, science and engineering in schools.

Languages

Language skills are crucial to the competitiveness of Scotland. I want to develop a comprehensive **National Languages Strategy**, building on the best international practice, to deliver a cultural step change in language skills by 2015. That should include a rolling programme to **introduce a second language early into the primary curriculum**, and support for more language immersion projects, with more Foreign Language Assistants to support the work of primary teachers. This strategy should include action to prepare Scottish pupils to meet global economic, cultural and social challenges. And progress made in schools needs to be maintained in our universities and colleges.

Positive about young people

If I am elected First Minister in May 2007 I will lead a government that spends its time focusing on the positive contribution that young people make. We must devote more energy to developing and helping young people - not demonising and blaming them.

I want to invest in all our young people, starting with our youngest children and continuing as they progress through school into training and work. There is no investment that is more important to our nation's future.

Future of Scotland Bill

I will lead a government that does more for young people: capturing their imagination, sparking their enthusiasm, giving them a voice, listening to their views, getting them involved.



Young people

Young people priorities

- › Schools open at evenings and weekends to offer new activities.
- › Young Opportunity Fund to support youth projects.
- › More outdoor activity and education for young people.
- › Votes at 16.
- › Give young people new rights through a Future of Scotland Bill and youth councils.

If we can inspire young people, give them the creativity and the confidence to challenge what they see and to dream great things, then they will have the power to influence their own lives, their own futures and the future of the planet.

If I am elected First Minister in May, for the first time in Scottish history a government will bring forward a piece of legislation to guarantee a positive role for young people; to give them the power and influence to get things done for their own lives and their communities.

The **Future of Scotland Bill** will ensure that young people have genuine access to power and a clear set of rights; that there is sufficient provision at national and local level to guarantee the proper representation of young people and to co-ordinate policy; and that young people have genuine access to a range of core services and activities designed to improve their lives and help them to meet their potential.

Capturing their imagination

It frustrates me when I walk past a school in the evening and see the gates locked and all the lights turned out. It gets worse when I turn the corner and see a group of young people bored and with nothing to do. No wonder too many children fail to achieve their potential.

I want to **turn our schools into community hubs** for everyone's benefit, all day and every weekend with a requirement for local authorities to publish plans to increase significantly the use of school facilities in their area at evenings and weekends. I want to see more investment for young people after the school day ends, including learning, play, sport, art, music, drama and homework clubs.

New activities

Our Young Opportunity Fund will make a real difference to the lives of young people across Scotland, providing financial support for a range of positive

policies. **Every child will be entitled to two weeks of outdoor activity** during their time at secondary school, allowing them to learn new skills and better understand their environment.

I want to target investment at clubs offering sport, leisure, music, art and environmental activities during evenings, weekends and school holidays. Our Young Opportunity Fund will also offer **Bright Future Support Grants with up to £100 funding for young people from low income backgrounds** to help towards equipment and materials to support their interests.

We will **cut the cost of access to sport and leisure facilities** to help encourage more young people to use the facilities on offer, with funding to support local schemes, particularly during school holidays.

The fund will also support a wider range of physical activities that appeal to young people who are turned off by traditional sports. **More use of dance, aerobics, rollerblading and other activities as part of the PE curriculum** and out of school activities will help.

And because improving the health of children and young people is so important, we will set a **new target for every child to receive an hour of physical activity every day. 1,000 new sports coaches and PE teachers will help to get things done.** We will get Scotland's sports clubs more involved with a new **fund to support local sports clubs that work with schools** to meet the new target for physical activity.

I will give greater political priority to youth work, consulting on a **new statutory duty on Ministers and local authorities to support youth work provision to a defined minimum standard**, with greater access to youth work for all young people. We will **pilot three 'super youth club' facilities** and implement a new **National Youth Strategy**, building on the year of action recently announced.

I believe that extending youth work has an important part to play in tackling antisocial behaviour. More 'outreach' youth work, where workers go out to work with disengaged young people, has an important role to play.





The Future of Scotland Bill will give young people in Scotland a real voice.

- › **genuine access to power and
a clear set of rights**
 - › **exciting new activities**
 - › **Young Opportunity Fund**
- 



We think young people should have a say.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Young people

Local initiatives to tackle antisocial behaviour should focus on engaging with young people to ensure **adequate alternative facilities are provided**. Young people themselves must be involved in the development of local antisocial behaviour strategies and this should be integrated as much as possible with the National Youth Work Strategy. I want to see more successful schemes such as **midnight football, basketball leagues, youth cafes and other innovative approaches**.

Empowering young people

The Future of Scotland Bill will **entrench the rights of young people in decision-making across Scotland**. I want this Bill to ensure that young people have the opportunity to influence the decisions that affect them in their schools, their communities and at a national level. Involving young people in decision-making should begin at an early age **with a pupil council in every school**.

Youth councils should be established in every council area with real powers of scrutiny over council activities that affect young people most, using innovative new ways to involve wider groups of young people.

Bringing in two young people to sit on the team tasked with sorting out the problems at the Scottish Qualifications Authority was one of the best decisions we took. Rather than be overwhelmed by the experience, they rose to the challenge and I believe that their involvement was really important.

Not enough young people are actively involved in the decisions taken by public sector bodies across Scotland. That is something that I want to change. Wherever appropriate, **young people should be represented on the boards of a range of public sector organisations**.

I want to encourage **greater involvement in the Scottish Youth Parliament, ensuring they are consulted on decisions affecting young people, supporting them to roll out nationwide elections**.

We will involve them in the work of the Scottish Parliament, with ministerial question times to scrutinise government Ministers, and the opportunity to introduce a Bill through the Committee system.

I believe that the time is right to **reduce the voting age for council and Scottish Parliament elections to 16**. I will make it a priority as Scotland's First Minister to push the UK Government for the powers to make this happen.

Giving more young people a vote is a start but it is only a small part of involving them in the decisions that affect them. Many will not take up the opportunities to sit on youth councils or public bodies. That is why it is crucial that in bringing forward our new youth strategy, we concentrate on increasing participation and empowerment. That means supporting children and young people to achieve change which is meaningful to them.

Our young people are at their best when they are empowered to help themselves. The Young Opportunity Fund will **provide support to roll out YouthBanks across Scotland**, ensuring at least one in every local authority area. These YouthBanks will be run by young people for young people and will provide small grants to fund their good ideas - whether they are more youth cafes, skateparks, buying new sports equipment, improving leisure activities, or other local improvements and small projects.

I want to see a **new national youth leadership programme to train tomorrow's leaders today**. This will increase the opportunities for young people aged 16 to 19 to develop the skills and confidence to become leaders within their communities. Ongoing practical training and a summer residential course will help them develop a range of leadership, team-building and communication skills. We will work with voluntary groups and the private sector to support this innovative scheme, working with 200 young people nominated by youth groups and schools each year.

I also want to support a new route for young people to help themselves through **Youth Community Enterprises** –

a new form of non-profit distributing business to include young people in a range of community activities. I want to continue to **support volunteering** in all its forms to encourage ongoing activity as well as one-off gap year projects. We will consider the options for a **new unit in Project Scotland to develop opportunities for young people to undertake work and voluntary placements in international organisations**.

Vulnerable young people

Our agenda for young people must leave no one behind. There are around 12,000 'looked after' children in Scotland. Only 1 per cent of all looked after children go on to higher education compared to 50 per cent of the general population; 46 per cent of young women and 59 per cent of young men leave school without any qualifications.

We must reconnect and give an effective voice to young people in care and the most vulnerable children. We will require a national audit of needs and services to ensure quality placements for all children who need them, backed by a national research strategy into best practice and improving outcomes for looked after children. There should be a throughcare and aftercare plan in place for all looked after young people. We will continue to support public campaigns to increase the number of foster parents and we will consult on the options to increase the time that looked after young people can receive support beyond age 16, up to 25 where necessary. We also want to introduce a **pilot of supported accommodation available to vulnerable young people leaving care** or leaving home with onsite staff to provide support. We will also **support greater use of leadership academies** which work to better prepare young people with the skills they need before they leave care.

To help improve access for looked after children to skills, training, tuition and the things that many children take for granted, we will **consult on the options for a Bright Future Fund for Looked After Children**.





We think a million young people matter.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Enterprise and economy

“My aim is a nation and an economy that every young person across the world will want to be part of; one that every enterprising person will look to first; and that gives those in Scotland the drive, ambition and dynamism to create world-class, world-beating ideas and turn them into a business reality.”



Dynamic Scotland

I want to create a dynamic Scotland that benefits from sustainable economic growth. Scotland has companies of global scale that are expanding across the world. Some companies in our financial services sector have grown for centuries and want to grow more, opening up in new parts of the world.

Our energy industries, built for the North Sea, now have huge global potential with the opportunity to win new export business in Africa, Russia, the Middle East, China and India. And they are moving into offshore renewable energy, using their skills and know-how for a brand new industry with the potential to create thousands of jobs.

Scottish higher education has a global reputation for excellence. It needs to be turned to practical economic benefit. Our universities have helped create major new businesses in electronics and life sciences. These new companies are tackling the biggest killers of the westernised world – cancer and cardiovascular disease – and have the potential to become the biggest businesses, with the best products, saving lives across the planet.

When the private sector gets united support from government, our universities and the wider public sector, the Scottish economy grows. We need industry, government and education to co-operate more strongly than ever.

I will continue to make sustainable economic growth a national priority. And to ensure that government and its

departments remain focused on this objective, we will **publish economic forecasts for Scotland and require departments to demonstrate how they contribute to sustainable economic growth** as part of the annual budget process.

To create this bright future for Scotland's economy I believe there are six key priorities: a more competitive Scotland; world class infrastructure; investment in industry; skills and training; excellence and internationalism; and cutting regulation.

A more competitive Scotland

Business rates

I want to see a more competitive Scotland. I have already reduced business rates. This was one of my policy priorities when I became leader of the Liberal Democrats. Scottish business will save £180 million per year. This cut in business costs has been widely welcomed. I now want to go further.

Under the Scottish Liberal Democrat Business Action Plan, I will **cut business rate poundage to below levels in the rest of the UK** to give Scottish businesses a real competitive edge.

I will maintain Scottish business rates below levels in the rest of the UK for the term of the next Scottish Parliament.





We think Scotland can be more competitive.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Enterprise and economy

Enterprise priorities

- › **Lower business rates to below levels in the rest of the UK.**
- › **Innovation and Investment Agency to deliver threefold increase in business R&D.**
- › **Cut unnecessary red tape and regulation.**
- › **More young people into education, training and work with more vocational skills.**
- › **Invest in further and higher education and scrap the graduate endowment.**

I want to give local authorities a real incentive to grow the local economy. That is why under the Action Plan, we will **allow local councils to retain all business rate receipts generated above a target and trend rather than surrender them to the central pool**. Each council will then have complete freedom to spend that money how it sees fit. I believe that many will recognise the virtuous circle that can be achieved by reinvesting some of this new income into projects to support and grow business in their area. I believe that this scheme will give very real incentives to local authorities to grow their economy, benefiting them and business.

I also want to see more businesses working with local authorities to improve the area. I will support the **roll out of Business Improvement Districts (BIDs)** across Scotland which allow businesses to come together to vote to invest collectively in local improvements in the area.

Small business

The **small business rates relief** scheme has been a major success, but I believe that we should go further by **doubling the existing support for small business**. This will lead to real savings for small business.

I also want to make it work even better for small businesses by allowing them to make **five year applications rather than annual applications**, with a requirement for firms to inform of a change to rateable values in that time.

We will also extend support by **ending the 'negative' system of transitional rates relief** so that businesses benefit immediately from reduced rateable values, but retain the 'positive' transitional support when bills rise.

I will introduce a **Small Retailers Support Fund**. This will allow local authorities to extend discretionary rates relief to 100 per cent for small, independent

shops designated as having a vital community benefit.

We can deliver real opportunity to Scotland's micro and small business sector by **improving their access to micro credit, encouraging innovative new partnerships that allow them to compete with more established players, and changing public procurement rules**.

We will also ensure that businesses receive the tailored support they need from the Business Gateway service.

World class infrastructure

In government in Scotland, Scottish Liberal Democrats have increased significantly expenditure on vital infrastructure such as transport, telecommunications, and renewable energy. This new higher level of investment needs to be maintained if we are to see a real difference. Our plans for investing in transport infrastructure are set out in detail in the transport section of this manifesto.

I want to **ensure that the National Planning Framework for Scotland is developed quickly and is subject to detailed consultation by the Scottish Parliament and a range of stakeholders**. However, detailed consultation must not mean an overly lengthy decision making process and once decisions are taken, they must be implemented efficiently.

The old system of private bills in the Scottish Parliament for new railways has seen major delays in approving major public transport projects. That is why we will implement the Transport and Works (Scotland) Act to streamline and quicken the process for approving new projects.

I am **opposed to the UK Labour Government's plans for a national planning gain supplement** to replace local Section 75 agreements. At the very least, any scheme must ensure that all funds from Scotland are returned to Scotland.

One of the concerns raised with me by business, time and again, is the ability of Scottish Water to deliver new investment in water and sewerage infrastructure. Scottish





Water has made real progress recently. However I believe that it can achieve much more.

I want to **free Scottish Water from the constraints of the public sector and allow it to operate in a more efficient manner as a mutual company**, owned by its customers. This will allow Scottish Water to deliver a better quality service at lower cost to Scottish householders and businesses.

This change in ownership would make Scottish Water directly answerable to its mutual holders, the Scottish public, and all profits would be retained for further investment and customer savings.

We will **legislate to ensure that the future de-mutualisation or privatisation of Scottish Water is prohibited**.

Every community in Scotland now has broadband coverage. I want to continue to improve broadband coverage across Scotland and work with providers to **ensure that all of Scotland benefits from the roll out of the next generation of broadband**.

To get more people and businesses connected and provide coverage across whole towns and cities, I will **introduce a WiFi Towns and Cities Fund**. It will make funding available to pilot the introduction of free wireless broadband internet across cities and towns in Scotland.

New technology offers new ways of working across Scotland. Embracing this technology will reduce congestion and have major environmental benefits. Those organisations that have embraced technology and new working practices have seen real benefits in reduced costs, better workforce retention and increased productivity.

I want to see more home and remote working in the public and private sector. I will **support the development of a network of Remote Working Centres** to act as hub centres where home and distance workers can use shared office facilities. These hubs will be located nearer to where people live so that we can reduce commuting into major towns and cities. Where possible they will be linked to the development of wider community facilities.

Enterprise and economy



Investment in industry

Scottish Enterprise

I believe that government should give strong support to the business leaders who invest their time, knowledge and expertise at all levels in Scottish Enterprise and its Local Enterprise Companies, as well as Scotland's business organisations.

That is why **I will support Scottish Enterprise and Highlands and Islands Enterprise in delivering their plans to grow Scotland's economy.** Those who say the enterprise agencies must be scrapped or slashed must explain how they will deliver their functions in skills and training, in investment in industry, in regeneration. Too often other parties call for changes without saying what new bodies they will set up to take over, or complain vociferously if Enterprise agencies suggest cutbacks or changes to the service. We will be consistent.

Innovation

Access to venture capital remains a major issue for Scottish businesses with high growth potential. Despite the success of Scotland's new business angel sector, many renewable energy and life science companies struggle to raise funds.

The Executive's co-investment fund has helped, but I believe there is a great opportunity to do much more. This is one area where a financial services sector working with government and industry could make a major difference. In the past Scotland benefited from the work of 3i - originally supported by Scotland's banks. The challenge today is just as great. **I will work with the Scottish Banks and financial institutions to increase access to venture capital in Scotland.**

It is also a high priority to tackle Scotland's historically low investment in research, development and innovation. Industry in Scotland currently spends around £500 million a year on R&D – one half of the UK average and a miserable fifth of Sweden's. In Finland, R&D levels have risen steadily as a percentage of GDP for the past decade. We need to

follow these examples by giving this issue a far higher profile.

In Scotland we are delivering among the best trained and educated young people. The challenge for business and government is to use this excellent resource and raise R&D levels here into the top OECD quartile within the next ten years.

I will set a **new long term target for a threefold increase in business research and development in Scotland.** And to make this ambition a reality and drive progress, I will **establish an Investment and Innovation Agency** in Scotland, bringing together current research and development, proof of concept, incubator, venture capital, and equity support from government. The Investment and Innovation Agency will follow best practice from around the world including the Finnish innovation agency TEKES. We will consult on whether the agency sits best within Scottish Enterprise and Highlands and Islands Enterprise.

Skills and training

Significant skills shortages are emerging in important sectors of our economy. At the same time, tens of thousands of young Scots are not in education, employment or training (NEET).

We need to do more to support this group of disadvantaged and often disaffected young people, with a big expansion of the vocational education opportunities in our schools and colleges. We need to make the most of the hidden talent in Scotland.

Vocational training

Our colleges should work far more closely with our schools and a higher priority must be given to vocational courses. Young people must be given the chance to undertake vocational education whenever it is most appropriate to them personally, and this should be in





the most appropriate educational setting, be it school, college or in the workplace.

To support this work we will **commit to a three per cent per year real terms increase to further education funding** over the next spending review. This will allow us to **roll out the successful Skills for Work courses** across Scotland to improve the opportunities for 14 to 16 year olds to undergo vocational and work based training to learn a trade and new skills.

That will mean **more support for partnerships between schools, colleges and businesses** to expand and improve the range of vocational courses available from age 14, giving more young people the opportunity to learn new vocational skills. This increased support will help address capacity issues and transport costs.

I want to **pilot new business incubators in schools and further education colleges** which can attract and develop those young people who are liable to fall into the NEET category.

These incubators would see entrepreneurs and business people getting involved with small groups of young people to foster entrepreneurial skills and give them the chance to strike out on their own or develop their skills through social enterprises.

Investing in training and skills makes a real difference. An independent evaluation of the Modern Apprenticeships and Skillseekers schemes showed that every £1 invested by Scottish Enterprise levered in almost £9 in added value through improved productivity, more training and increased recruitment. To build on this success I want to reach a **new target of 50,000 Modern Apprenticeships by 2011**. In setting this new target we will review the operation of the scheme to increase flexibility and simplify procedures for business.

Transitions to training and work

We need to do more to support young people before, during and after the critical transition stages from school into training, learning and work.

Enterprise and economy

I will ensure that a **Key Worker service is available to all young people who need it to provide intensive one to one advice and support.** And to make sure that young people don't slip through the net, I want to see a systematic follow-up service for school leavers thought to be at risk of falling into the NEET group. We will support Careers Scotland, working in partnership with schools and local authorities to deliver these services.

Lifelong learning

If we are to compete globally we need to encourage a culture of genuine lifelong learning. I want to make it easier for people of any age to add to their skills, change their careers, and develop their passion for learning. I want to see **greater parity of esteem** through a Scottish credit framework that recognises the value of vocational training and continuous learning. Careers Scotland will continue to play an important role in efforts to improve outcomes for young people, but it is important that it remains an all age careers service. We will **merge Careers Scotland and Learndirect Scotland**, recognising the close links between careers advice and lifelong learning opportunities.

Excellence and internationalism

Further and higher education

We need to give the strongest possible support to Scotland's industries with world class potential. Our universities and colleges are a huge strength for Scotland, with an excellent reputation right around the globe. It is vital that we maintain high levels of investment in further and higher education.

That is why I am committed to continue the record investment in further and higher education to build on the last spending review which took investment to over £1.6 billion. I want to see **new investment in university buildings, making new funding available to improve facilities, and update and renew equipment.** This funding should also be used

to increase undergraduate and postgraduate places. I want to see **more done to retain and attract the best staff to Scotland** with more discretionary funds for recruitment, greater use of research pooling among Scotland's universities, and a joint fund among government, universities and private benefactors for highly prestigious awards. Scottish Liberal Democrats will **support the call from Universities Scotland to increase investment in our universities** by an extra £168 million by the end of the next term of the Scottish Parliament.

For Scotland's universities to remain competitive, they need more than public funding. In the United States there is a well established culture of philanthropy towards further and higher education and in many states this has been backed up by the action of government. Government matched funding schemes operate in 24 US States and succeeded in raising an additional \$276 million from private donors from an investment of just \$87 million in state funding in a 4 year period.

Our excellent universities have the potential to lever in new private investment. The Universities of Edinburgh and Aberdeen are examples of what can be done. Edinburgh is half way to reaching a target of raising £350 million through private investment and donations. I want to **work with colleges and universities to consider the options for a matched funding scheme or other support to lever in additional private investment, delivered through new funding, not top-slicing.**

Our universities also have a key role to play in meeting Scotland's economic potential. They already make a major contribution to our economy, but I believe we can do much more to meet Scotland's potential through government, business and universities working together. There are big opportunities for Scotland, especially in sectors such as financial services, energy and life sciences. Renewable energy alone could deliver tens of thousands of new jobs and billions of pounds of new investment if we can capture a share of the potential global market.

I want to encourage better links between research and industry. I want to work with universities on the spin-out of research. **Every college and university should have**

an enterprise centre and business incubators, in partnership with corporate Scotland. And I will ask the Scottish Funding Council to work with business groups to consider whether changes are needed to the Research Assessment Exercise to ensure it supports research which has a practical business and economic outcome.

Government must also give strong backing to Scottish businesses, colleges and universities developing new opportunities in India, China, and other major markets.

Students and learners

Ultimately the biggest support that we can give students in Scotland's universities is to continue to invest at record levels in higher education. A degree from a Scottish university must continue to offer excellent opportunities for life, where students can use their skills and talents and earn the rewards that come from study.

I am extremely proud that it was the Liberal Democrats who brought about the abolition of tuition fees and the reintroduction of grants in Scotland. The contrast is stark between the decisions taken on student finance with Liberal Democrats in government in Scotland and by Labour governing on its own in Westminster.

Scottish Liberal Democrats will **steadfastly oppose the introduction of student top-up fees in Scotland.** The next step for student funding is to take further action to reduce the burden of debt for young people and ensure that fear of debt is not a barrier to an excellent education.

As Scotland's First Minister I will **ensure that Scottish graduates no longer have to pay the graduate endowment.** I will include the provisions to scrap the endowment in the Future of Scotland Bill which will be introduced to Parliament in June 2007. I will **maintain the fund that supports those students in most need** through maintenance grants and bursaries and **increase the level of bursaries given to the poorest students above inflation.**

I will establish a **National Widening Access Unit** to increase the numbers of students from poorer



- 
- › scrap the graduate endowment
 - › record investment in colleges and universities
 - › higher grants for the poorest students



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Enterprise and economy



backgrounds entering further and higher education. The Unit will work in schools to raise expectations and aspirations, particularly among families with little or no history of attending college or university.

I will also launch a **review of means testing in Higher Education** and consider introducing a **new minimum income guarantee for students**, met through varying combinations of bursaries, loans and parental contributions. There should be more flexibility in the student loans system so that payments to students are tailored to suit their circumstances.

Too many people are put off part time study by the costs which act as a barrier to participation and retention. We will **review the support system for part time learners to increase support in meeting fee and study costs**. There should be greater equality of treatment between full and part time students, whether studying at college or university.

And to ensure that today's students prosper as tomorrow's employees I want to see a **major increase in the number of students undertaking a work placement** as an integral aspect of their course.

Cutting regulation

Government must realise the huge impact it can have, particularly on small and medium sized business. While a lot of red tape is created in Brussels or at Westminster, the role of the Scottish Executive and its agencies - especially Scottish Water, SNH and SEPA - remains significant. Scottish Liberal Democrats want a new **Red Tape Action Plan** to take action to reduce this burden.

Often it is not individual rules or regulations that cause problems, but the cumulative effect of a number of them. I believe that the key to reducing this burden on business is to **move to a more proportionate system of regulation based on a proper assessment of risk**.

It makes little sense to apply the same inspection and regulation requirements to a business with an excellent track record in meeting its regulatory obligations, as to



another that regularly bends or flouts the rules. Inspection should be focused on areas of greatest risk. **Those businesses that consistently meet high standards should be rewarded through a reduction in the burden of inspection and regulation.**

I will **implement the Hampton Report** (on more efficient approaches to regulatory inspection and enforcement) **and the Macrory Review** (on effective regulatory penalties). We will cut red tape and bureaucracy through a more risk based approach to regulatory inspection and enforcement with a Scottish Action Plan where progress is measured as part of the Improving Regulation in Scotland (IRIS) Unit annual report. I want to **increase the resources of the IRIS Unit** and ensure its **annual report is scrutinised by industry itself** through the Regulatory Review Sub-group of the Small Business Consultative Group (SBCG) and by the Scottish Parliament.

Parliaments are often very good at passing new regulations and legislation and not so good at reviewing their impact. For **regulations with a significant impact on business I want to see a review after four to five years** to determine their impact, effectiveness and cost, with input from business itself.

We will establish an industry led group, including small business, to review regulatory processes in Scotland with the aim of reducing the administrative burden on the private sector by 25 per cent.

While many of the regulators that impact on businesses operate in different spheres of government, it cannot be beyond us to limit the amount of management time spent dealing with inspections. I want to see **more joint inspections** by government agencies. This is a big agenda for government and business but it's one I'm determined to tackle. I want to **pilot a new initiative with SEPA to move to a more proportionate risk based system** of regulation and enforcement.

At times new regulation is supported by industry. Scotch Whisky is one of Scotland's major export success stories. We will work with the industry to support proposals to **codify further the definition and presentation of**

Scotch Whisky in legislation and ensure the new European Spirit Drinks Regulation meets the needs of the Scotch Whisky industry.

Procurement

More must also be done to make it easier for small companies to do business with government. A great example is to **encourage the NHS in Scotland to buy more from our new life sciences companies.**

Other action should include reforming public procurement rules to create a level playing field for all businesses to apply for contracts, opening the market to more SMEs, social enterprises and consortia of smaller companies.

Central purchasing should not rule out local purchasing. The **McLelland report** on improving government procurement is a good start – but now the challenge is to deliver. I want to see a **single Scottish portal to advertise all public sector opportunities.** To cut advertising costs, we will also introduce a **single online recruitment portal for the public sector.**

Social responsibility

As a recent Economist report suggests, GDP is not the only measure of progress. I want to **supplement GDP with other measures which look at quality of life.**

These will reflect Scotland's ability to attract and retain new talent more accurately than a measure of GDP alone can. Crucially, these measures need to focus more on outcomes than on inputs. We will measure **quality of life in Scotland** against our neighbours and competitors to change the culture across government.

The companies that succeed in the future will be the ones that act in a socially responsible way. The benefits to businesses, employees, communities and the environment can be significant and I want to do what I can to help Scottish companies to make corporate social responsibility (CSR) a part of their everyday business, and not a public relations add on. This is what the best global companies

are now committed to – and the same must happen in Scotland. We need to **develop a framework for the promotion of CSR in Scotland.**

Social enterprise has a major role to play in fostering entrepreneurship and in service delivery and community action across Scotland. I want **greater recognition and support for social enterprise models.**

Greening business

It is estimated that around £250 million of energy is wasted by Scottish businesses each year. Experience has shown that businesses which adopt a range of simple no-cost and low-cost energy reducing measures can typically save 20 per cent on their fuel bills. For those who invest in energy efficient equipment, such as condensing boilers, compressors or variable speed drives, savings can be even greater - in some cases in excess of 30 per cent. This represents a financial saving of more than £50 million pounds per annum.

Those companies that have already invested have reduced their energy use, costs and carbon emissions. But there's no point in saving money on energy bills only to see business rate bills go up because this investment forms part of the rateable value. I want to bring forward **changes to the system of business rate valuations to encourage small businesses to make the green switch** to micropower and energy efficiency. I also want to extend support to **businesses to invest in energy efficiency and microgeneration** through the Loan Action Scotland scheme, providing an additional £4 million over the term of the next Scottish Parliament.

As government action helps to drive down purchase and installation prices for micropower and energy efficiency, payback periods will tumble and those making the green switch will see recurring savings flow much faster.

A major agenda for the next term of the Scottish Parliament is a significant increase in the amount of business waste that is recycled. Sustainable waste management itself is an area of huge potential for new green jobs.



Environment

“Climate change is the biggest challenge facing our generation. If we are to take it seriously we need to take action in every area of Scottish society. We will ensure that Scotland reduces greenhouse gas emissions through an effective and ambitious climate change policy.”



Climate change

I want Scotland to be bold on climate change. I am determined that Scotland should be the renewables powerhouse of Europe. I want Scotland to take a leading role in tackling the challenge of global warming.

That's why we've made a **commitment that Scotland will do more than its share in reducing the UK's carbon emissions**. That target should be just the start. During the term of the next Scottish Parliament we will set a higher target for carbon saving in Scotland. We will **introduce specific and ambitious targets to reduce carbon emissions with a 4 year overall carbon reduction target and an annual report to Parliament on progress** towards meeting that target. This will include individual targets by sector. The annual report to Parliament will track Scotland's progress in meeting a **12.5 per cent reduction by 2010 and 60 per cent by 2050**. We will also work with the UK Government to ensure the UK plays a leading role in establishing a robust agreement on targets to reduce significantly global emissions beyond 2012, particularly in the transport sector.

When people talk about cuts of 60 per cent in greenhouse gas emissions it can at times seem unachievable. Yet with strong leadership, it can be done. Woking Council has cut its greenhouse gas emissions by 72 per cent and its energy consumption by 44 per cent. That's an inspirational figure. I will establish a **Carbon Challenge Demonstration Fund** to support innovative low carbon developments and help towns and cities in Scotland achieve

similar results. To mitigate the effects of climate change at home, I want to see the development of sustainable flood management strategies and investment to reduce the impact of flooding on Scotland's people, species and habitats as far as possible. And to play our part abroad, I want Scotland to develop an **overseas climate change team** to do more to assist developing countries to adapt to the impacts of climate change, deal with climate-related disasters and adopt low carbon technologies. We will **double the current provision made by the Scottish Executive for overseas aid**.

Energy use and generation

Some 70 per cent of global greenhouse gas emissions come from energy production and use. If we are truly to achieve a sustainable future, **energy use reduction needs to be at the heart of our energy policy with a clear strategy to reduce demand across society**. It's as much about reducing demand for energy as it is about generating new clean energy.

Within the next two decades, five of Scotland's main power stations (fossil fuel and nuclear power) are due to be decommissioned, and our energy infrastructure will require a major programme of investment. We must seize this opportunity to make the radical changes necessary to revolutionise our demand, production and use of energy in Scotland. We have to turn the system on its head.

I believe that means putting energy reduction higher up the political agenda. I will introduce a radical package of





We think Scotland can be greener.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Environment

Environmental priorities

- › **100 per cent renewable electricity with major investment in wave and tidal power.**
- › **Reduce energy demands with investment in energy efficiency, microgeneration and local power.**
- › **Reduce waste and increase recycling rates to 70 per cent by 2020.**
- › **Cut carbon emissions with 4 year targets and an annual report to Parliament.**
- › **Make every school an eco-school and improve environmental education.**

measures to do just that. All areas of society must play a part: government, business, communities, households. I want to see more decentralised energy, microgeneration, energy efficiency and renewable energy, to reduce energy demand and carbon emissions across Scotland.

A good start would be to stop the rate of growth in energy demand, however that should be only the start. To drive this ambition forward we will **consult on the introduction of a new target to reduce electricity use by 20 per cent by 2050**. And to help achieve it, we will set bold new targets for overall energy reduction, energy efficiency measures, renewable energy, renewable heat and microgeneration.

Microgeneration and energy efficiency

As Minister for Enterprise, I've visited many community and household renewable projects. There's one factor that stands out above all: the massive culture change that comes with generating your own electricity. Rarely does a household or a community embark on a renewable energy project and not 'catch the bug'. Often they go on to invest more in energy efficiency, recycling and other environmental projects.

That's one of the reasons I want to put Scotland at the lead of a micropower revolution. If each home in Scotland installed a simple micropower device we would generate 17 per cent of all our electricity consumption from clean green renewable sources. Families would save hundreds of pounds in fuel costs. **That is why I want all new homes to have microgeneration.**

Microgeneration must go hand in hand, wherever possible, with increased energy efficiency. There is little point in generating more local power if that energy is wasted because of inefficient buildings.

Improving energy efficiency is the easiest and most cost-effective means of reducing carbon emissions. **That is why I want all new homes to meet high levels of energy efficiency through tighter building regulations. So from 2010 I want all new buildings - private and**

public - to use onsite micropower to generate at least a fifth of the building's energy needs.

I will take forward this pledge to reduce energy demands from housing, business and government in a new **energy efficiency and microgeneration strategy**, including setting challenging targets for microgeneration and more energy efficient homes.

Healthy green homes

Ambitious new targets for microgeneration and energy efficiency in new buildings are important so that our homes and offices of the future meet high environmental standards. However retrofitting existing buildings is even more critical and there are two compelling reasons to do more: cutting fuel poverty and improving public health.

It's time we acted upon the linkages between poor health, environmental unsustainability and poverty. That's why we should make the green switch for Scotland's homes. We can improve public health, help the environment, and tackle fuel poverty by acting now.

I am committed to ending fuel poverty by 2016.

According to the Scottish House Condition Survey an estimated 328,000 households in Scotland were fuel poor in 2003/04. There are around 33,000 children living in fuel poverty - a sobering statistic when you consider what could be achieved. In Helsinki I saw two new energy efficient flats that only needed to be heated three months of the year, when temperatures fell below zero. Applied to Scotland, this approach could save a family hundreds of pounds every year.

I believe that creating **warm, dry homes is one of the top public health priorities for Scotland**. It's a disgrace that every year in Scotland, winter brings with it a spike in what are known as 'excess winter deaths'. In too many cases these are easily avoidable. Almost 3,000 deaths a year are linked to living in cold, damp housing.

They may be only the tip of the morbidity iceberg. We know that poor housing conditions play a significant role in determining when someone dies, but there is increasing





evidence of the much wider impact on health and quality of life that cold, damp homes have in Scotland.

Tackling this problem needs holistic action. That's why I will bring together the existing programmes into a **new Healthy Green Homes Fund, to act as a one stop shop for the public on energy issues**. It will bring together work currently undertaken through the Warm Deal, Central Heating Programme, and Scottish Community and Householder Renewables Initiative (SCHRI). Its key objectives will be to bring Scotland's housing stock up to standard, cut carbon emissions, improve public health and save households hundreds of pounds every year in fuel costs. **This new fund will upgrade at least 40,000 homes every year from 2009.**

When someone applies for a healthy green homes grant, they will receive a single assessment of their eligibility for energy efficiency measures, central heating, microgeneration, and smart meter installation. People on benefits and low incomes will gain the most. This will effectively **extend the Warm Deal and Central Heating programmes so that in addition to qualifying for energy efficiency, low income households will also be offered free installation of appropriate microgeneration technology and smart metering**. A benefits check will be another important aspect of the grant scheme giving help to ensure that people are claiming everything they are entitled to.

As part of the Fund we will **increase the support available to housing associations and local authorities** to ensure that they can meet new individual targets for installing **microgeneration and energy efficiency measures** in their properties.

I believe that more can be achieved by the public and private sector working together. That is why I will work with the electricity companies to see how leveraging in their investment into the Healthy Green Homes Fund can work to allow us to do more, and them to meet their Energy Efficiency Commitment.

I also want to see more action to tackle fuel poverty on a local, area by area basis. As part of the Healthy Green Homes initiative, I will support the **introduction of**



Environment

Warm Zones to target fuel poor households and ensure they receive the funding support available to them.

And to make the link between fuel poverty and poor health absolutely clear, I want to see much greater use of referral schemes where health professionals, care workers, and other community services act as trusted intermediaries to point people in fuel poverty towards the healthy green homes team.

The fund will also continue to support private homeowners looking for **grant support to install microgeneration or improve energy efficiency** in their homes. As government action helps to drive down purchase and installation prices, payback periods will tumble and those households making the green switch will see recurring savings flow much faster.

To drive take-up further, we will seek the legislative changes necessary so that **homeowners who install new microgeneration during the term of the next parliament can benefit from a one-off £200 rebate on local tax bills. Those who also invest in energy efficiency measures will be eligible for a further £100 rebate.**

And to address the growing number of people living in fuel poverty in the private rental sector, we will give more support to local authorities to work in partnership with landlords, including low and zero interest loans and a grant support scheme for buildings in multiple occupation.

Planning rules need to change to make it easier to install microrenewables by making them **permitted development**. Investment in training is needed through our employers and colleges to increase the number of **skilled installers**. And so that conversion, renovation and investment in energy efficiency is not disadvantaged compared with new build projects, I want to **press the Westminster Government to reform VAT and guarantee that microgenerated electricity can be sold back to the grid at market rate.**

When energy ratings for washing machines and fridges were first launched they were treated with some scepticism. Today sales of A-rated appliances are surging ahead.

Manufacturers are increasingly rising to the challenge and consumers are fuelling demand.

We need a similar approach with housing. I want to see **energy performance certificates** which change hands as part of single seller surveys and tenancy agreements. It's also time to raise our ambitions for thermal efficiency in new build properties. I will ensure that the **review of building standards for 2009 sees a further increase in thermal efficiency requirements** to take us nearer to the best performing Scandinavian countries. We must do more to monitor the actual thermal performance of new buildings - not the theoretical.

Green governance

I believe that the public sector can do a lot to drive the micropower and energy efficiency revolution.

My long term objective is for renewable energy to be generated on-site in every building. To achieve that vision I want **every part of the public sector** to develop an action plan so they too **generate at least a fifth of their own energy** on-site by 2020. Hospitals, schools, prisons, offices, leisure centres – all must be part of the green energy revolution.

Ensuring that this target is met for our schools is particularly important. They will see their fuel bills come down, Scotland will see its carbon emissions drop, but perhaps just as importantly the next generation will catch the renewables bug too. And because it's so important that this happens, I will make sure that **all school building projects have to include microgeneration**, energy efficiency and sustainable building techniques.

Smart metering technology in schools and homes will show people the cost of the energy they use. It will also show just how much money their mini wind turbine or solar panel saves them. It will bring learning to life. It will help people to become more energy efficient.

I want to build on the 2003 Liberal Democrat commitment which led to investment of £20 million in public sector energy efficiency. That investment is delivering £70 million

in savings in five years and recurring savings of £30 million per year thereafter. I want to **double that fund again so it can do more.** This will **deliver even greater energy savings** and cut carbon emissions still further.

I will **encourage the use of global footprint tools** in the Scottish Executive, its agencies and in local authorities across Scotland to inform decisions to reduce Scotland's ecological footprint.

I also want **all Scottish Executive buildings and transport to be carbon neutral by 2012.**

We will ensure there is genuine representation of environmental interests and expertise across government, with proper integration of sustainable development. And to ensure that sustainable development is practised throughout every area of government, we will expand the remit of the Audit Committee to include an assessment of each Scottish Executive Department's commitments to sustainable development. It will be renamed the **Sustainable Development and Audit Committee.**

Local energy and renewable heat

At the moment more than 60 per cent of the energy from big fossil fuel power stations goes up the chimney as wasted heat.

I reject our old centralised system of electricity generation with its massive carbon dinosaurs and its nuclear follies. I reject its inherent inefficiency with two thirds of fossil fuel wasted as heat. I reject its carbon emissions which contribute to global warming. I reject its legacy for future generations – with nuclear waste remaining radioactive for hundreds of thousands of years.

By generating on a smaller scale, more locally, this heat can be piped to homes and businesses. By using combined heat and power (CHP) we can double the efficiency of fossil fuels and make existing reserves last longer. But as quickly as possible we need to see a switch to renewable sources - burning biomass in these CHP plants instead.

A decentralised system will mean our energy demands go





We think we can reduce our ecological footprint.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Environment

down, not up. It will tackle head-on the problems of climate change, pollution, energy security and cost.

I want to **create local power in every community in Scotland**, including combined heat and power, district heating systems, air and ground heat pumps, microrenewables, biomass, storage cells, smart grid technology, a network of hydrogen fuel pumps, and support for innovative hydrogen storage systems such as the PURE centre in Shetland.

We must take the forthcoming end-of-life closures of key power plants in Scotland as a strategic opportunity to remodel our electricity system on a more decentralised basis. We must be ambitious. Decentralised energy is already successful in Denmark, providing more than 50 per cent of electricity supplies, while in the Netherlands over 40 per cent is supplied through decentralised energy. Copenhagen's underground heat network pumps hot water from local decentralised power stations into people's homes and offices, alongside electricity.

A recent study of the potential for decentralised energy in Edinburgh shows that we can follow this lead. In fact it demonstrates that only a decentralised energy approach will put cities like Edinburgh on the way to meeting the 2050 carbon reduction targets, with our capital city able to cut more than a quarter of its carbon emissions by 2025 under this approach. As a start, I want the **Glasgow Commonwealth Games Village to follow a decentralised energy model**.

I will make developing plans for more decentralised energy a key element of our Energy Bill. And to drive our ambitions forward we will **consult on a new requirement for all new power stations to include cogeneration** of electricity and heat, or have adequately demonstrated that heat capture is not possible, before granting consent for new projects. We will also **consult on the introduction of new enterprise models such as energy services companies (ESCOs)** that can deliver local low emission energy. I also want to see the current limits on the development of private wires removed.

Some 80 per cent of energy in homes is used for heating. That's why I want a **new renewable heat strategy**

for Scotland to cut carbon emissions, shift to more renewable energy sources, increase efficiency and provide an alternative to fossil fuels.

We will **set a target for 10 per cent of Scotland's heat needs to come from renewable and microgeneration sources by 2020**. We will work, through a **Biomass Action Plan**, to encourage production by farmers and provide the resources for a major expansion in combined heat and power. Studies suggest that biomass could deliver around 450MW of electricity in Scotland. Further information is in the rural section of this manifesto.

Renewable energy

Electricity generation accounts for 37 per cent of all greenhouse gas emissions in Scotland. That is why making the switch to clean, green renewable energy is so important. **My vision is for Scotland to become the green energy powerhouse of Europe**. The Liberal Democrats are determined to support this vital investment and reject new nuclear power in Scotland. **Scotland does not need new nuclear power**. We do not need the risk, the waste, or the cost. New nuclear power would drain money and political will from investment in clean, green renewable energy.

Instead, Liberal Democrats want a renewables revolution for Scotland. We've made great progress in Scotland and are on course to beat our target of 40 per cent of electricity from renewable sources by 2020. Now it's time to go further.

So what is my ambition for Scotland in 2050? **I say renewable energy supplying 100 per cent of Scotland's electricity. 100 per cent by 2050**. That sounds bold. It is deliberately bold.

It can happen, but people – and politicians – need to make it happen. We will start now by **raising the existing 40 per cent target to 60 per cent by 2020**.

The huge untapped power of Scotland's seas offers a massive opportunity for us to generate more clean energy.

I want to see wave machines generating electricity in Scottish waters by the end of 2007.

We can become the marine powerhouse for the world, exporting technology and expertise, creating thousands of new jobs and billions of pounds of new investment. That's why I will support more new wave and tidal power projects through the Marine Energy Fund and the **extended green credits support for the marine industry** to ensure we meet this potential.

We cannot afford to miss out on the economic benefits of being a technology exporter. This is what happened with wind power, the benefits going to Denmark, Germany and other nations that invested in the new technology. That is why I will continue to push for major changes to the grid system to help the renewables industry grow in Scotland.

This will involve upgrading the mainland grid and major new investment in the development of grid cabling offshore. We will lobby the UK Government for the revision of OFGEM's remit to have sustainable development as its primary role, ensuring that marine cables are treated fairly for electricity distribution in the long term. We will **give our support to plans for an offshore 'supergrid'** so that Scotland develops its full renewables potential.

Small community wind projects have real potential to deliver local benefits. I want to see more communities get involved, with government support for bulk purchase options for procuring, delivering, erecting and maintaining wind turbines in the most cost effective way. We must ensure that renewable energy developments bring real and lasting benefits to local communities.

Our energy future will be about embracing new technologies. In the short term we must develop **carbon capture** and **clean coal** technology. In the medium term we must realise the massive potential from **hydrogen technologies** and fuel cell storage. We support the creation of the world's first industrial-scale hydrogen power scheme at Peterhead which will re-inject carbon dioxide under the ocean floor and create around a thousand new jobs. By being at the cutting edge of the new technology, we can meet our energy needs and secure a low carbon economy. I am determined we will.





We think Scotland can be a renewables powerhouse.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Environment

Green food miles

As a nation we are becoming increasingly aware of the benefits to our health and the environment of choosing more local, fresh, seasonal produce. I am determined that the public sector will do its bit and take the lead in buying local, healthy food. European public procurement rules prohibit the use of food miles as a criteria, but a recent pilot in East Ayrshire schools has shown how procurement rules can promote local, fresh, healthy produce. **We will roll this project out to all schools** in Scotland, making fresh food with minimal packaging and specific delivery times a requirement for contracts. And we will go further still, learning the lessons from the pilot in schools **and applying them to all public sector organisations**. For more information on our plans to cut food miles see the Rural development section.

Waste management

Recycling rates have trebled in Scotland under the Liberal Democrats. I want to see them continue to rise so that Scotland moves to the top of the European table and leads the green jobs revolution. Scotland must reduce its ecological footprint but we won't do that if we keep dumping our rubbish in landfill sites.

The principle behind everything we do must be to minimise waste as much as possible. We need to redesign our one-way industrial system into a circular system where waste becomes an asset rather than a liability. I want to see us strive to ensure that almost everything is ultimately recyclable or reusable - setting us on a path towards a zero waste Scotland.

Reduce and reuse

I want to work with manufacturers and retailers to build sustainable design into products, remove unnecessary packaging, and develop lighter packaging. I also want to reduce the volume of unsolicited goods and materials such as junk mail by encouraging the use of delisting options.

We will continue to work with the UK retail sector and the UK Government to reduce the environmental impact of plastic bags by 25 per cent by 2008, with more encouragement to consumers to reduce their carrier bag use, reducing the plastic content in bags, and enabling the recycling of more carrier bags. However we will keep the option to legislate for a plastic bag levy open if significant progress towards this target is not made. We will also consider the options for similar provisions to reduce unsolicited goods and materials.

Recycle

I want to see municipal recycling and composting **rates increase to 70 per cent by 2020**, with milestones to ensure progress is made towards this ambitious target. I want to work with councils to set **individual targets** to help bring the poorer performing councils up to standard and build on the progress of the best performing.

We need to give consumers real incentives to recycle and we must make it simple and straightforward for them to make the green switch to recycling.

I want to see **kerbside recycling extended** across the country. New developments must include community composting and waste separation facilities as standard so that the problems faced with existing tenement buildings are not repeated in the future. Children should be actively involved in **recycling at schools** so that they understand the concept from an early age.

Between 17 and 20 per cent of the average household bin is filled with food waste. We must do more to divert this away from landfill. We will **support an increase in the use of home composting. We will rollout the successful digester bin schemes developed in Aberdeen and other areas** to reduce the amount of waste put out for collection.

I also want to see a **major push to reduce business waste and improve recycling in the business sector over the term of the next Scottish Parliament**. This should include a **new target to increase business**

waste recycling with more targeted services for small and medium sized companies, and projects to increase recycling at major business parks and centres.

We will look at the options for introducing a deposit on recyclable drinks containers that would be refunded when the container is presented for recycling.

Energy from waste schemes will only be supported in very limited circumstances and only where it can be demonstrated that all reasonable steps are being taken to reduce or reuse waste and that all materials capable of being recycled have been extracted.

Natural environment

We do not yet live in a sustainable Scotland; wildlife species and habitats are still being lost. The importance of the environment to our society is often taken for granted.

We recognise the value of our natural heritage to Scotland's economy and social wellbeing, and seek to ensure its preservation and enhancement.

Environmental crime

I want to see **better investigation and prosecution of environmental and wildlife crime** with better resources, environmental police officers, more training for prosecutors and increased penalties for environmental crimes. We will **further consider the establishment of an independent decision-making system for determining the use or abuse of environmental assets**, including the options for a civil environmental tribunal and environmental court to hear legal appeals on these issues.

Wildlife and habitats

Biodiversity has an important role to play in the social and economic life in Scotland, contributing to the wellbeing of Scotland through access to wildlife-rich



green spaces and increasingly through green tourism jobs. Scottish Liberal Democrats want to protect and enhance Scotland's biodiversity through the effective implementation and enforcement of the Nature Conservation (Scotland) 2004 Act and the Scottish Biodiversity Strategy, with more coordinated action to secure the effective protection of Scotland's threatened species and habitats.

We are **committed to halt the loss of biodiversity by 2010** to prevent any further loss of Scotland's natural heritage. We will consider the case for improving the indicators selected to assess progress towards these goals by working with the Scottish Biodiversity Forum, and increasing funding for the Biodiversity Action Plan grant scheme. We will consult on extending the existing target of features cited in SSSIs that are in 'favourable condition' from 80 per cent by 2008 to 100 per cent by 2010.

As part of our plans to improve wildlife habitats, we want to see more emphasis on **planting native species within forestry**.

We will **ensure that EU Life+ funding is brought to Scotland** and used for the enhancement of our most valuable and endangered species and habitats. In particular we will work to preserve and improve our peatlands, which are important as carbon sinks as well as for their unique bio-diversity.

Landscape

Scotland's landscape is celebrated around the world. It is cherished by people across Scotland and is a major part of the tourism experience for many visitors to Scotland. It is important that we protect this natural asset.

We will **consult on the options for new legislation to renew National Scenic Areas** as a useful tool for protecting landscape. This could include the ability to create new NSAs, review boundaries and management and give provisions for promotion of NSAs.

Recreation and access

Walking and outdoor activities are growing in popularity in Scotland and have major benefits to individuals and to the economy through the development of new outdoor business opportunities across Scotland. I want to continue to improve access to Scotland's environment.

We will **fund the implementation of the Land Reform legislation on access** with adequate resources for path networks, outdoor education, access officers and access forums. We will provide **long term funding for developing a core path network** via Land Management Contract incentives and ensure that local authorities develop Core Path Plans to improve public access throughout their area.

We recognise the links between environment, activity and good health. We will ensure that Strategic Environmental Assessment takes proper account of these links between good health and wellbeing and the environment. More information on our policies to protect and promote greenspace is in the Communities section of this manifesto.

Water environment

We will continue to **implement the Water Framework Directive and the River Basin Management Plan** to ensure both improvements to the purity of Scotland's rivers and the sustainability of biodiversity within our river basins.

We will also implement measures to address the problems of diffuse pollution and we will meet the requirements of the Nitrate Vulnerable Zones Directive with measures that are effective and proportionate.

Recent flooding incidents across Scotland highlight the need to **introduce sustainable flood management policies** that reduce the damage caused by flooding, ensure protection and enhancement of the environment and act as a sustainable solution to adapting to the impacts of climate change. We will include flood management measures within Land Management Contract prescriptions.

We will also review the relevant legislation relating to flooding to ensure it remains fit for purpose.

Marine environment

To recognise the importance of Scotland's marine resources, we will **introduce a Scottish Marine Bill** to provide a coherent framework for managing our seas, including measures for marine spatial planning, conservation and sea fisheries.

Powers over the marine environment are currently a mix of devolved and reserved areas. In bringing forward the Scottish Marine Bill, we will **seek the agreement of Westminster for the Scottish Parliament to have exclusive jurisdiction out to the 200 mile limit** over marine spatial planning and marine conservation, building on its current powers over sea fisheries and offshore renewable energy.

We will also build on the wide support, in principle, for a **coastal and marine national park** by consulting widely with community and sectoral interest groups on the most appropriate location and form of governance.

Environment education

I want **every school to become an eco school, with them all working towards green flag status. I want to improve the standard of environmental education**, with more outdoor learning to introduce school children to nature and wildlife. Environment education should teach children about the need to reduce our ecological footprint. We will put sustainable development education at the heart of school life.

When the whole school takes a hands-on approach to reducing its footprint through more recycling, using local food, encouraging walking and cycling to school and discouraging the school run, growing vegetables onsite, putting in micro wind turbines or solar panels, and regularly visiting local wildlife areas, then children will really learn about how to protect our environment throughout life.



Health and wellbeing

“I want to see excellent health care services in communities across Scotland. I believe that the future of health care must be local and personal. Investing in more local health care can deliver faster diagnosis and treatment for patients across Scotland.”



More local health care

Last year I visited a new style of hospital - a newly built community health centre. I saw frontline professionals from hospitals, other health disciplines, social work and the voluntary sector working together to plan and deliver more flexible services. Services that replace the need for a 94 year-old person to be rushed with blue lights to a big hospital 25 miles away for something that can be dealt with calmly - and safely - locally.

With more power, local health teams can do even more, all over Scotland. My priority for health in Scotland is to treat more people, more quickly, more appropriately, closer to home. Every community should have access to improved local health facilities, with a wider range of services under the same roof.

Over 90 per cent of healthcare is now delivered locally and people across Scotland are already benefiting from increased investment in local health care facilities. The time is right for a step change in investment to deliver excellent local facilities across Scotland.

Health centres and community hospitals

That is why the Scottish Liberal Democrats want to **begin a major building programme for 100 new local health centres**. In many cases that will mean new, modern, purpose built facilities. In some areas it will mean **expanding the capability of community hospitals to**

provide minor surgery, or funds to improve the facilities and services on offer at existing health centres.

I want **our 100 existing community hospitals** to have a greater role and give more support to the work of local GPs. I want them to have responsibility to treat more people - particularly the elderly and those with chronic illnesses - closer to home. To make this model of local healthcare work, we need to **break down the barriers between health and council social care services** with staff working together in one location to provide better care for all patients. To make this happen we will intensify work on the Joint Futures agenda.

That will also mean developing and strengthening the links between primary care teams, ensuring that a wider range of services are delivered in the community. I want to see greater co-operation between GPs, pharmacists, nurses, allied health professionals, optometrists and dentists to deliver improved patient outcomes.

Nurses

I want to **recruit an additional 2,000 nurses**, with many based in our new local health centres, working in the local community as part of our local health teams. I want to encourage **further specialisation of roles in the nursing profession** so that we make the most of their talents. I want to see more nurses with specialist training in dealing with chronic conditions so that they can work with people to manage their own condition. In short we



- 
- › 100 new and refurbished local health centres
 - › 2,000 extra nurses
 - › faster diagnosis and treatment
 - › 200 extra NHS dentists



We think healthcare should be local.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Health and wellbeing

Health priorities

- › **200 extra dentists so everyone has access to an NHS dentist.**
- › **100 new and refurbished local health centres.**
- › **2,000 extra nurses.**
- › **Faster diagnosis and treatment with a new waiting time guarantee.**
- › **Better children's health with free fruit in primary schools and more cookery lessons.**

must **broaden the career structure available to nurses** and give them a greater role in service provision at all levels. As part of a wider review of the nursing profession we will also **consider the case for improving financial support to student nurses.**

Pharmacists

Community pharmacists should have more powers to prescribe and treat patients, lessening the burden on GPs. This should include more diagnostic and screening work. The potential for pharmacists to do more as part of the local health team is significant and their reach into high streets and communities across Scotland is impressive.

We want to **make the system of prescription charges fairer**. We will limit the maximum amount that anyone has to pay to one prescription per month. Any prescriptions over and above that will be free to all. We will maintain a system of exemptions for pensioners, people on low incomes and those with chronic illnesses so that they will continue to pay nothing. The cost of abolishing all prescription charges is around £40 million per annum and rising. We think that this money is better spent on extra dentists and nurses.

Allied health professionals

We must continue to increase the numbers of allied health professionals (physiotherapists, podiatrists, occupational therapists and others), ensuring that all disciplines are adequately staffed and ready to meet the challenges of more local health care.

We will recruit a further **500 allied health professionals (AHPs)**, developing new public health practitioners and AHP consultant roles. Increasingly allied health professionals must be seen as vital members of the community health team, working seamlessly with GPs and other primary care providers in Local Health Centres and Community Hospitals. We will consult on introducing '**protection of title**' so that only registered, qualified AHPs can use these titles.

In the United States, the fourth fastest growing occupation group is physician assistants - health care professionals licensed to practise medicine under a physician's supervision. They are having a real impact in the US where they are used to conduct physical exams, diagnose and treat illnesses, order and interpret tests, counsel on preventive health care, assist in surgery, and in many cases write prescriptions. **We will trial and evaluate the introduction of new physician assistants to the NHS with a view to rolling these out across primary care teams** if they demonstrate a positive benefit.

Violence against health and social care workers is unacceptable and a growing concern. We will **consult on the options to increase the protection for these important workers.**

Dentistry

Scottish Liberal Democrats have introduced free dental checks across Scotland, but we recognise that for some people accessing a NHS dentist remains a real problem.

That is why we will launch a new recruitment drive to bring in an **additional 200 dentists** to Scotland to work primarily as salaried NHS dentists in areas where access to NHS dentists is most difficult. And to ensure that the supply of dentists continues to increase we will support the **establishment of an Aberdeen Dental School**. We will also look at the options for improving children's oral health through more use of salaried dentists undertaking check ups in schools in deprived areas. Focusing on improving oral health in children will ultimately reduce the burden on the service in the future.

Tackling delayed discharge

By investing in community hospitals and improving joint working between health and social care services we can do more to tackle the problem of delayed discharge, allowing more older people to leave acute hospitals sooner and be treated locally.



To support this shift in emphasis I want to encourage a more flexible career structure across health and social care disciplines as part of a review to bring social work legislation up to date, and improve training, development and workforce planning in social work. We must use the **latest technology to support older people to live longer in their own homes.**

Rural health

Delivering health services in rural Scotland has its own challenges, but it is vital to these communities that we ensure high quality provision. That is why we will **introduce a strategy for sustaining small rural and community hospitals** as part of a network of rural hospitals to support our remote communities. We will also **establish a Clinical School for Rural Health Care** to ensure workforce development and promote the use of general consultants to undertake routine procedures.

Rural Scotland can benefit from new technology that reduces the need to travel to big hospitals. I want to see a major expansion in tele-medicine. We will **establish a Tele-health Technology Resource Centre (TTRC)**, based in Aberdeen, to develop nationally applicable approaches to tele-health. Where people need to be transferred for specialist medical treatment quickly we will ensure that the service is in place, including **support for the Orkney Air Ambulance Service.**

Social enterprises have the potential to do more in the health service, particularly in rural areas where they can be used to sustain services. We will **establish a dedicated social enterprise unit in the health department** to encourage the development of the sector in Scotland.

Involving people in health

The health service must be flexible if it is to meet modern needs. That means that there may be occasions when facilities must close because they are no longer fit for purpose because of their age, demographic pressures or changes in clinical practice. However, consultations must

be much more meaningful.

Communities must be involved at the very beginning of a process to redesign services, not just at the end. Where they have one, Boards should state at the outset what their preferred option is. The views of communities ought not to be ignored, nor should Boards give the impression of so doing. There should be more democratic accountability in decision making, but this will not be achieved by direct elections to Health Boards. Instead we want to see a much **greater scrutiny role for local government over health services in their area**, with local scrutiny panels. To build public trust and confidence, **Health Boards should avoid closing NHS facilities until new or better suited facilities are in place.**

A better deal for Scotland's carers

There are some 480,000 carers and at least 17,000 young carers in Scotland today delivering services which would cost in the region of £5.5 billion if paid for from the public purse. Many of them face ill health themselves. I want a better deal for Scotland's carers, recognising the difficult but vital work they do.

We will work with existing providers to **establish a comprehensive network of Carers' Centres**. This will include core funding for permanent staff to reduce the feeling of isolation for carers, to offer advice, assistance and training, and particularly to help carers access services and benefits. We will **increase the number of carers who receive a carer's assessment each year** to ensure that their needs are met, with particular emphasis on support for young carers. Many carers are unable to take a break of longer than a couple of days. I want to **improve support so that they can take longer breaks** and work with councils to improve the process of commissioning services for carers.

Sensory impairment

Waiting times for access to audiology services vary considerably across Scotland with waits of up to 99 weeks

recorded for one Health Board. I believe that more focus needs to be given to reducing this wait for audiology services and fitting of digital hearing aids. We will introduce a **new 26 week maximum audiology waiting time guarantee by 2009** with a view to reducing further waiting times **to 18 weeks by 2012**. BSL is the first or preferred language of around 4,300 deaf people in Scotland, but many report that they struggle to access sign language interpreters. We want to **increase the number of BSL interpreters** so that deaf people can have better access to sign language interpreters when they need them. We will also implement the recommendations of the recent sensory impairment review, particularly improving the provision of specialist mental health services.

We also want to develop a **National Vision Strategy for Scotland**, identifying the key needs to meet the social, educational, health and employment needs of blind and visually impaired people.

Faster diagnosis and treatment

In 2003 we made hospital waiting times a major priority so that those who had been waiting the longest got the treatment they desperately needed. Today, no one with a waiting time guarantee waits more than six months between referral by a consultant and treatment. We are on track to meet new 18 week waiting time targets by the end of 2007. I believe that the next major challenge in reducing the wait and the worry for patients is to deliver on faster diagnosis.

In Sweden, the government has progressively introduced a number of maximum waiting time guarantees so people know what to expect from the health service. Rather than just offering a guarantee for the time between a decision being taken to treat a patient and their receiving an operation, the Swedes set out maximum waits for the whole patient journey - a total waiting time guarantee. I want to learn from this approach so that people in Scotland have a clearer idea of what to expect when they fall ill.



Health and wellbeing

If I am elected First Minister in May, I will instruct the Health Minister to undertake a full **consultation on introducing a new Total Waiting Time Guarantee (TWTG)**. Under this guarantee we will set out maximum waiting times for access to primary care, GPs, diagnostics, consultant referrals and treatment. It will be based on a maximum wait of 186 days - just over six months, following a **new model of 1-5-90-90**. This means you can access a member of the primary care team within a day, have a full consultation with a GP within 5 days, receive diagnostic tests within 90 days, and receive treatment within a further 90 days.

Access to primary care

Each aspect of the TWTG relates to a maximum number of days waiting. It means that when people first feel ill or seek help for non-emergency treatment, they will get **access to a member of the primary care team within a day**. A growing number of GP consultations can be dealt with effectively by other members of the team - a practice nurse, allied health professional, physician assistant or specialist pharmacist. Our investment in new and improved local health centres will mean that people will have access to these primary care staff in well equipped facilities close to where they live.

Access to GPs

When a patient needs to see a GP, there will be a maximum waiting time of 5 days. In most cases the wait will be a lot less than this, however in other areas this new maximum waiting time will give GPs flexibility to balance new appointments with those seeking to book an appointment in advance. This will allow a more personalised approach, with greater flexibility for patients and doctors.

Access to tests and diagnosis

If the GP refers the patient on to a specialist, **the waiting time for diagnosis will be a maximum of 90 days**.

There is no good reason why many simple diagnostic tests could not be done locally. This would speed up the process considerably, meaning that the consultant sees you for the first time armed with the test results and information needed.

To make that first specialist appointment more meaningful, **local health workers will undertake more tests at the time of referral**. Our investment in new local health centres will make that happen with a **shift to more diagnostic investigations in the primary care sector** - particularly ultrasound, CT and MRI scans and endoscopy - and new investment in equipment and staff to increase capacity so that we get the most use out of these important machines and reduce waiting times further.

For common illnesses, conducting these tests in the community will sometimes rule out a problem before a patient even needs to see a consultant. Unnecessary waiting, travelling and worrying will be reduced. That in turn will free up consultants to cut waiting times for people who are in urgent need of treatment. And just as importantly, an early diagnosis undertaken in the community will give doctors the chance to manage an illness before the patient sees a specialist.

We want **GPs to have more options for referral** so that where colleagues in primary care have a specialist interest or knowledge, GPs can refer to them directly.

We will also invest in new technology so that more tele-diagnosis can happen across Scotland, reducing the need to travel unnecessarily.

Faster treatment

From the time the specialist decides that treatment is required, patients will have a maximum waiting time of 90 days to receive that treatment. Again we can improve the experience for patients by introducing **new nurse and AHP led pre-admission clinics** accessed in advance of their elective operation so that certain tests and assessments can be carried out prior to the procedure.

The same clinics would also be able to plan for the

discharge of patients, agreeing with them the level of community support necessary and making sure that colleagues in health and social care are ready and waiting.

Scottish Liberal Democrats endorse the principles in the report of Professor David Kerr on modernising the NHS. One of the major recommendations of that report is **separating out planned and unscheduled care. This will be a major part of cutting waiting times** and achieving the new 90 day maximum. Too often you hear from people about how a planned operation was cancelled at the last minute. It's not difficult to see how this can happen. They are often complex procedures that need to have everything in place. When an emergency case comes in, it often takes precedence and requires key staff, equipment or operating theatres. That is why we want to see more regional planning to separate out planned and unscheduled care. This will help cut waiting times significantly - particularly for procedures with the longest waits.

This new Total Waiting Time Guarantee is ambitious and requires a shift in emphasis across the NHS to more local health care and more co-operation between the primary and acute sectors. This is a challenging agenda for the whole of the NHS in Scotland and it will take time to deliver. I want this new 1-5-90-90 day guarantee to be met for at least 80 per cent of patients by December 2011.

Technology and patient information

New technology can speed up diagnosis and treatment across the NHS. Technology is not a panacea but can be used effectively to improve the service to patients. I hear too often of problems and delays caused by lost medical records, test results mislaid and therefore tests repeated. We should **move to an individual electronic health record**. More personalised healthcare will mean more effective treatment in the future.

However our investment in technology should also go hand in hand with investment in people. Sometimes patients, often the poor or most vulnerable, get lost in the system. I want to **increase support for patient**



- › **new Total Waiting Time Guarantee**
- › **first day treatment for primary care**
- › **maximum 5 day wait for GP consultation**
- › **maximum 90 day wait for diagnosis**
- › **maximum 90 day wait for treatment**



We think waiting times should be shorter.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Health and wellbeing

advocacy so that people can access trained, impartial advocates to help when they have a problem in the system. We will place a duty on Boards to ensure access to patient advocates in their area.

Tackling Scotland's biggest killers

Scotland has one of the highest death rates from Coronary Heart Disease (CHD) in the western world - attributed to poor diet, high rates of smoking and deprivation. However, progress is being made. We will continue to implement the CHD and Stroke Strategy, making sure we make progress towards our **aim to reduce deaths from CHD in the under 75s by 60 per cent by 2010**.

Survival rates for most cancers are continuing to improve, but tackling Scotland's high cancer rate continues to be a major challenge. Projections suggest that cancer incidence rates will increase by around 28 per cent by 2020, meaning that more people will require treatment for a wide range of cancers. The **Scottish Cancer Strategy** has helped focus action, with new regional cancer networks and action to cut waiting times. We will **review the Strategy to update it**, ensuring the full involvement of clinicians, patients, researchers and other stakeholders.

Scotland already has successful breast and cervical cancer screening programmes. Bowel cancer is the second biggest cancer killer after lung cancer. Recent pilots suggest that a national screening programme could save around 150 lives every year. That is why we will phase in a **national bowel cancer screening programme to all health board areas by 2009**.

Smoking is by far the largest preventable cause of cancer in Scotland, while dietary factors may be responsible for up to 30 per cent of cancers. That is why continuing our focus on improving public health is so important.

We will continue to make progress on the three national clinical priority areas of CHD / stroke, cancer and mental health, but we will also **add respiratory diseases and Alzheimer's and other degenerative diseases to make five national priority areas in total**.

Healthcare associated infection

We will continue to make combating HAI a high priority through the HAI Task Force. We will continue to invest in measures such as hand washing and alcohol wipes to combat infections. We will ensure that precautions are also effective against new and growing infections such as *C. difficile*. We will ensure that Sisters and Charge Nurses have the authority to require local cleaning services to act on problems identified.

Reducing inequalities

Male life expectancy in Glasgow is almost eight years less than in East Dunbartonshire. This shocking statistic is all the more potent for the fact that the two areas share a boundary. The truth, of course, is that poverty and poor health are not confined by lines on maps. We need to tackle inequalities in health wherever they exist.

Inequalities in health aren't just seen in health outcomes. A study in the west of Scotland showed that the average GP consultation time was two minutes shorter for deprived patients.

Reducing inequalities in health means adopting the principles of preventative and anticipatory medicine, with targeting to ensure that people in deprived areas have better opportunities to be seen and have their problems dealt with at an early stage.

Preventative care

Everyone knows that prevention is better than cure. I want to see more preventative and anticipatory care through the NHS, before acute treatment is necessary. Again, this model of preventative care will often be better delivered in local communities with health care workers co-operating with social care staff, carers and patients themselves to anticipate health problems and prevent, as far as possible, health care crises from developing.

The mortality rate for CHD among the under 65s is over

four times higher for the most deprived ten per cent of the population than for the most affluent ten per cent. Research also shows that there are fewer medical interventions among the most deprived patients with CHD than the most affluent.

That is why it is important to continue the work started under the Keep Well (formerly Prevention 2010) project which is looking at how to anticipate and prevent ill health among the target population of 45 to 64 year olds at risk of serious ill health. There are now 12 anticipatory care pilots operating through Community Health Partnerships in Greater Glasgow, Lothian, Tayside and North Lanarkshire, Fife, Ayrshire & Arran, and Grampian. Backed by an additional £25 million, these pilots are strengthening primary care services in deprived areas to identify those at particular risk of preventable, serious ill health and offering health checks, screening and advice.

We will **evaluate these anticipatory care pilots at the earliest possible opportunity, setting clear national objectives, and providing the resources to roll these out across Scotland**. This should include **developing new ways to give easy access to men** - who are often reluctant to visit their GP - to screening and health check services in the community.

We will also implement the SIGN guidelines on tackling CHD and strokes and **increase our support for the use of statins** - medicines that cut the risk of heart disease by helping to lower cholesterol.

Long term conditions

Around a third of the population at any one time will be suffering from one or more long term conditions - chronic conditions like diabetes and high blood pressure. The long term trend is clear. Our ageing population and increasing life expectancy means that more people will live with long term conditions. In 25 years' time, there will be more people in Scotland who are of retirement age than there will be children. And many of these will be the oldest in society with a doubling of the over 80s from around 200,000 to 400,000.





We think prevention is always better than cure.
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Most people have heard about the problems of delayed discharge when a patient stays in an acute hospital bed for longer than they need because there isn't the necessary support in the community. Not many people know that the vast majority of delayed discharges are from patients admitted on an emergency basis. Many of these could be avoided by better patient management and support.

We want to see **more support for preventative and anticipatory care, helping people to manage their illness at home and in local health centres** rather than waiting for them to appear on the radar only when a crisis happens and they need acute care.

A person with diabetes will spend on average 3 hours with a health care professional and will take care of themselves for the remaining 8757 hours in a year. Investing more in this kind of support will save significant time, money and effort later if it avoids emergency hospital admissions.

There are around 100,000 people living with heart failure in Scotland. Improving support for the people who live with this serious, debilitating and life-threatening condition is an excellent example of how people in Scotland can benefit from a health service that is more focused on local action and individual patients.

Specialist heart failure nurses and clinics have been shown to reduce unnecessary hospital readmissions, improve quality of life and prolong survival for people with heart failure. The cost of providing new services can be significantly offset, if not wiped out, by the reduction in hospital admissions. We will review our provision of specialist heart failure nurses and clinics so that people across Scotland have improved access.

We support and recognise the right for people with terminal illness to die at home. The support of specialist nurses such as palliative care nurses is so important. We will assess the outcome of the Tayside Delivering Choice pilot scheme to see how it can be rolled out across Scotland to benefit patients and their carers by designing reliable palliative care services that will provide information, support and best possible care in the place of a patient's choice.

Too often there is a lack of dialogue between different health specialisms. **I want to bring together all the experts to see how advances in medicines and technology can prevent ill health**, save money in the long run and improve quality of life for people across Scotland. It's time to break down the barriers between the medical and non-medical worlds.

Health improvement

Last year The Economist magazine published a quality of life index for 111 countries across the world. The UK was ranked 29th - some 16 places below our GDP ranking. According to the magazine, GDP is just one of nine determinants of quality of life.

Improving public health and wellbeing is crucial to improving quality of life. For a country often burdened with the tag of the 'sick man of Europe', that's a major challenge. If we fail to recognise that the environment in which people live, work, study and play has a real impact on their health and wellbeing then we will quite simply fail to improve the health of our nation.

That is why I want to push ahead with the health improvement agenda. We're all in this together. Government, business and individuals all need to pull together. Too often government contradicts itself. People see examples every day. It's no good calling on children to take more exercise at the same time as playing fields are sold for housing. It's no good preaching healthy eating to people while the state still sells fatty, frozen, processed food. We need to encourage a responsible approach to food, drink and fitness.

Every single aspect of government needs to be focused on the links between public health and the environment we live in. Access to quality greenspace; living in warm, dry homes; the ability to cycle safely instead of using the car; breathing clean air: these are just as much matters of health as visiting your doctor or hospital.

Health improvement benefits the economy. Some 8.9 million scheduled workdays are lost every year in Scotland

due to absenteeism on the grounds of ill health. The Scottish Economic Report shows how a 5 per cent improvement in the percentage of the population undertaking regular physical exercise could reduce days lost to sickness by 7 per cent, save 157 lives, and reduce the cost to the NHS by millions of pounds each year. The boost to our economy from improving our health would be significant.

That's why it's time to make sure that all government action, all strategies, and all Bills are assessed for their impact on the health of the population and the environment. It's simple common sense, but too often gets lost in the system. We will **ensure that Strategic Environmental Assessment takes proper account of the relationship between good health and the environment.** This will help us target even more investment at tackling the root causes of poor health. It'll help us weed out the nanny state policies that serve only to limit freedom, not improve actual health. It'll direct us to improve our knowledge about what determines good health and what we can do about it.

Healthy local food

Scotland produces some of the finest food in the world, yet Scots display some of the worst eating habits. It's time to buy local and eat local. I'm determined that the public sector will do its bit and take the lead in buying healthy local food. It just makes sense. By reducing food miles, we can cut down on harmful carbon emissions. We can promote good health by eating our own locally grown produce. We can support our farmers and rural areas.

No organisation that is supported by taxpayers' money should contribute to poor health - they should all promote good health.

It may be controversial, but we need to change the culture that sees a leisure centre serving burgers, chips, crisps and fizzy drinks, but not healthy local food. It is ridiculous. It's not a matter of banning these foods, but **organisations funded by the taxpayer, be they public or private, must ensure that the bulk of the food they buy and**



serve is healthy local food. We must make it the rule, not the exception.

There must be a wider community push for healthy local food. Across the public sector the same principles of healthy nutritious food must apply, particularly in hospitals, nurseries and in meals for our older people. It's not right that hospital patients who need healthy nutritious food to aid their recovery can't always get it. I want to see **new nutritional standards for all hospital meals.** Those standards need to be based around ending the lunacy of food served in Scottish hospitals being shipped up from mass catering centres hundreds of miles away only to be reheated.

We need to improve how we plan our communities to encourage access to healthy food. **More allotments and community market gardens** that can supply local fruit and vegetables at low cost and advice and support for families are all important. We should also consider **supporting social enterprises to run their own healthy, low cost food shops from council premises at zero rent.** Health and planning need to go together.

Smoking

Scotland's ban on smoking in enclosed public places has been highly successful. The next step is to do more to reduce the number of children who smoke. There have been only a small number of prosecutions under the existing laws. We will **tackle under age smoking through a mandatory proof of age scheme, an extension of test purchasing, and heavy fines for retailers who knowingly sell to under 16s.** And to bring in real incentives for retailers not to sell to children, we will introduce a **negative licensing scheme so that repeat offenders can be prohibited from selling tobacco products.**

The Gruer report cites strong evidence that increasing the price of tobacco is the real factor in reducing

smoking by young people. We will **urge the UK Government to increase annually the price of tobacco products at a rate faster than inflation.**

Drugs and alcohol

The total cost to Scottish society of excess drinking is some £1.1 billion every year - equivalent to around 4 pence on income tax for all Scottish taxpayers. Soon the new licensing regime will come into force in Scotland, providing a much needed update to our licensing laws. It will stamp down on inappropriate drinks promotions that encourage binge drinking. It will also give local people significant new powers.

There is much to be done to achieve the long term culture change we need in Scotland. We need to achieve a more balanced and moderate approach to alcohol, rather than dreaming up new ways of inconveniencing people. A good start would be to extend action to tackle inappropriate drinks promotions to off-sales premises. I also want to see **test purchasing schemes extended** - where local police are able to enlist young people to 'test' whether pubs or shops will sell alcohol to underage customers. I welcome the moves by some organisations to **introduce a new Challenge 21 scheme to crack down on underage drinking.** I want all licence holders to follow this lead. We will review progress in two years and take action to make it a mandatory **'no proof, no sale'** scheme if the problem remains.

I also want to work with manufacturers and retailers to improve the information people have about alcohol, particularly relating to labelling and information on alcoholic strength.

I will require the establishment of a **national register of drug and alcohol services,** including residential placements, to improve knowledge of availability of places across Scotland. I will back this up with a **doubling of funding for drug and alcohol treatment - more than £100 million of additional funding over the next spending review.** This extra funding will be used to increase residential places, cut waiting times for

services, and create more family support posts to provide intensive early support to prevent crises developing.

Mental health

One in four people in Scotland will experience a mental health problem at some time in their life. Estimates of the total social and economic costs to Scotland of mental health problems were £8.6 billion in 2005. This underlines the importance of mainstreaming mental health and wellbeing across all areas of Scottish Executive activity.

We will **continue to treat mental health as one of our national clinical priorities.** I believe that we need to develop a cross-party, long term commitment to the promotion of mental health and wellbeing.

Having passed important ground-breaking legislation to put rights and treatment at the heart of the mental health system, I want us to continue to improve services and make the ambition in that legislation a reality. We should continue to **monitor the implementation and effect of the legislation to make changes where needed.** We will also implement the Delivering for Mental Health plan which has been developed by a range of stakeholders. It is particularly important that we **build the capacity of service users** so that they can be meaningfully involved in the design, delivery and evaluation of policy and services.

Sexual health

While progress has been made, I believe that there is still much more to do to improve sexual health services in Scotland, particularly for young people. Sexually transmitted infections (STIs) are on the rise in Scotland with rates of acute STIs doubling in the past decade.

We will **commit to sustainable funding to back up the Scottish Sexual Health Strategy from 2007 to 2011.** This long term investment will help build capacity and in turn address waiting times, with a view to introducing a **maximum wait of 48 hours to access GUM clinics.** It will also allow GPs and local health



Health and wellbeing

centres to employ family planning and GUM specialists. The funding will be ringfenced to ensure that these important services receive every penny. We will continue to support education campaigns for young people. We also want to see more specialist sexual health services located outwith traditional healthcare environments.

Children's health

Food in schools

I was shocked by the rise in childhood obesity levels when figures were published three years ago. One in five 4 to 5 year olds in Scotland is overweight. That figure rises to almost one in three 14 to 15 year olds. Over the past three decades, childhood diabetes rates have increased threefold, while asthma rates have also risen. We're sitting on a ticking timebomb and that's why we need to do more to improve children's health.

Nowhere is the challenge of improving our nation's eating habits more important than in our schools. We've made great progress in improving school meals to the point that food campaigner Jamie Oliver described us as 'light years ahead of England'. Soon we will remove junk food and fizzy drinks. But I want to go much further. I want to see **more investment in improving school meals, ensuring that they source the bulk of their food from local producers and suppliers.** We will also **extend free school meal entitlement to more families receiving working tax credit.**

Free fruit in schools has been a great success. Now it's time to extend it from P1 and P2 to all primary children and make sure that, where practical, **every school has a breakfast club** to give access to healthy food before school starts.

I want schools to buy more fresh, local produce, but I also want them to produce their own. We should look to the successful example of children in German kindergartens helping to bake the bread for the day, or projects in Italy that encourage children to create and look after school vegetable gardens.

There can be no better way to educate children about food than for them to grow their own, then learn how to prepare and cook it. It's frightening how little some children understand about where food comes from. How can we ever expect them to eat healthy food later in life if we don't educate them as children?

I want a major expansion in **cookery classes for children** throughout their time at school. That is a proportionate response to a real problem. And in some cases, we need to bring that support, help and advice to parents too. Teaching children about healthy living and emergency life support skills is also important.

Some children in Scotland continue to suffer from malnutrition and deficiencies in important vitamins and minerals. We will **consult on raising the nutritional guidelines in Scotland to promote good health and launch a pilot scheme to trial greater use of vitamin supplements** in schools.

Children's exercise

I want to introduce a **new Play Fund to refurbish, renovate and reinstate play areas** to inspire play, movement, sport and outdoor education for young people. We must beat the target of two hours of physical education (PE) every week for school pupils. It will not be easy, but we must be more ambitious and set a target for **every child to get one hour of physical activity every day.**

Young people need to be more involved in decisions about physical activity in schools, particularly those children who are not attracted to traditional sports. It doesn't have to be just formal sport, it can be informal play, aerobics, dancing - anything that raises the pulse and sparks the imagination. I believe that the benefits for the children involved and the communities they live in will be significant.

There is a wealth of local sports clubs across Scotland doing great work. In the Sport section we detail how we will support clubs that work with young people.

Children's health services

I want to see a truly national Children's Health Service operating across schools in every part of the country. That will mean **giving our school nurses a major boost**, both in terms of overall numbers, but also to improve their prospects and develop their role to put them truly at the heart of the health promotion agenda. School nurses, working together with nutritionists, teachers, active school co-ordinators and other health professionals, can motivate children and their parents to lead healthy lifestyles.

We need to introduce **personal health records for every child.** Coupled with regular health visits, these records should form the basis of action to improve children's health. I want children from any part of Scotland to be able to access specialist obesity services.

When a child has significant issues, the children's health service must step in to find ways to address the problem. It's not about stigmatising children, or playing the nanny state. It's about caring for the individual. Individualised health care should mean that no child is left behind because no one had the time, inclination or responsibility to see what could be done. In some cases parental involvement might be limited to meeting the school nurse at parents' evenings, for others more targeted support might be needed.

For many children, their contact with the children's health service might be limited. For others at high risk, there may be greater involvement. Early support is the guiding principle. All of this work must be underpinned by a much better assessment of the costs and benefits of investing in the children's health service. Investment now in our children's health will save a lot of money in the future.

We will **introduce Managed Clinical Networks for children's health services** to deliver a nationally consistent service, meeting agreed standards across Scotland. This will include better links between community services and acute care, and a smoother transition from children's to adult services, particularly for young people with disabilities.





- › 1 hour of physical activity per day
- › healthy local food in schools
- › free fruit for all primary children
- › more cookery classes
- › more school nurses



We think children's health matters.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Crime and justice

“I want to cut crime and make Scotland’s communities safer. We need more visible policing, where and when you need it. We need to take a more radical approach to cutting crime with a system that stops criminals from committing crimes time and again.”



Cutting crime

Victims of crime are often the poorest and most vulnerable in our society. Offenders often have poor educational attainment, few or no qualifications and lack stable employment. This doesn’t excuse crime. Liberal Democrats think what is needed is effective and radical action, not spin and gimmicks.

We have to do more to get to the root of offending behaviour. Not to exaggerate the crime levels in Scotland, but **genuinely to involve communities in local policing**. Not to erode civil liberties for everyone, but to make our justice system, efficient, effective and fair.

Community policing

I want to recruit **1,000 extra community police officers** to cut crime in neighbourhoods across Scotland. We will provide enough funding for the police to provide **at least two additional community police officers in every council ward** in Scotland to provide visible policing in communities. I want every Police Board to publish an **annual Community Policing Plan** setting out how they will deploy existing and additional officers. I want to see real joint working between community officers, community wardens, antisocial behaviour teams and council staff. And in each Community Policing Plan there should be a clear commitment to ensure adequate community cover.

Recruiting more community officers is just the first step in making communities safer. I want to introduce the **next**

generation of neighbourhood watch by improving the links between communities and their dedicated community officers. That will mean providing and circulating a dedicated mobile phone number for local officers. When officers are not on duty the number should patch through to the police control room. Community officers should provide email updates to local residents on law and order issues in their neighbourhood. So as well as supporting more police officers, we will make sure that there are funds in place to improve the communication between local officers and communities. I hear too often from people who say they don’t bother phoning the police to report a crime or their suspicions because they don’t think it’s worth it. That is where getting a **more direct link to local officers** can really help.

Sentencing to cut crime

There are three essential elements to sentencing policy: punishment of an offender; ensuring public safety; and rehabilitation. Scotland currently has one of the highest imprisonment rates in the world. Yet, despite this, reoffending rates continue to rise, with two thirds of offenders committing a further crime within two years of release from prison.

On any given day the bulk of prisoners in our jails will be serving very short term sentences with little time or provision to address their offending behaviour. Successive inspection reports from the Chief Inspector of Prisons have bemoaned the fact that short term stays and





We think 1,000 extra community police officers.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Crime and justice

Crime priorities

- › **1,000 extra community police officers.**
- › **Tougher community sentences to make offenders work to repay their crimes and cut reoffending.**
- › **Crack down on knife crime with 7 year maximum sentences.**
- › **Youth Justice Board and Youth Panels to cut youth crime.**
- › **Tackle Scotland's drug and alcohol culture.**

overcrowding mean that there is no chance for prison staff to work to rehabilitate inmates.

Too often time in prison is simply used to learn new skills for crime. Meanwhile overcrowding gets worse as the prison population rises and the prison door revolves.

Rehabilitation

If we want to cut crime in Scotland, we must address reoffending. I believe that we need to **change the mindset of our criminal justice system so that the goal of reducing reoffending is a key objective.** That means immediately looking at services to tackle the underlying reasons behind offending behaviour such as drug or alcohol use. It means sentencing policy that is better targeted on changing the behaviour of offenders and tackling the issues behind their offending. And it means a prison service and services in our communities working together to make sure we tackle the problems of poor literacy and numeracy, lack of housing, little or no employment history or skills, drug and alcohol problems, and poor mental health.

More effective sentences

Scotland's prison and sentencing framework is not working - it is not cutting crime and reoffending. In fact there is clear evidence that very short term prison sentences simply reinforce offending behaviour.

For all of these reasons, I want to **replace very short term prison sentences of three months and under with tougher community sentences that make offenders work to repay their crimes and cut reoffending.**

I want to see more use of effective alternatives to custody. We will ensure that there are community sentences that **combine the effect of probation orders and Supervised Attendance Orders so specific tailored conditions can be set on the offender** during the community sentence.

Nipping low level antisocial and criminal behaviour in the bud is important. When someone is caught vandalising a bus shelter or spraying graffiti, they should be made to face up to their offence and make amends by working in the community to undo the damage caused. I want to **increase the use of restorative justice measures such as Community Reparation Orders**, rolling them out across Scotland from 2008 onwards following the evaluation of the current pilot schemes.

I also want to go further with **Restorative Justice Panels** - where someone convicted from a district court is referred to a restorative justice panel (made up of members of the community and supported by professional staff) to agree measures that help to make amends to society and the community.

I believe that we need further reform of sentencing in two areas. First, there should be **greater use of conditional sentences for sentences of less than six months.** These would involve specified periods of imprisonment, backed up by tough conditions for community sentences, over a defined period to address offending behaviour. Breach of conditions will lead to serving the remainder of the community sentence in custody.

Second, Scottish Liberal Democrats want to **pilot the use of dual sentencing** where offenders return to court following the completion of the custodial part of their sentence for the judge to set the community part, with conditions on behaviour attached to the remainder of the sentence. This approach is already showing evidence of working in New York.

Reducing reoffending

In addition to making sentencing more effective, I want to change the way that we deal with prisoners, during their time in prison and on their release, in order to cut crime.

We will **replace the Scottish Prison Service with a new Scottish Custody and Rehabilitation Service**, transforming SPS into a prison and community based service that works directly with other services, businesses



and Criminal Justice Authorities to reduce reoffending. We will also **roll out a network of Community Justice Centres** based on the pilot of the community link centres where rehabilitation services are coordinated. The network would be coordinated by the Community Justice Authorities and work seamlessly with the new Custody and Rehabilitation Service.

Skills for work not crime

Being unemployed or lacking in basic skills is no excuse for antisocial or criminal behaviour. However, if we are to really cut crime, we must be aware of the issues that have to be overcome if we are to stop a criminal offending again. Lacking a stable job, decent housing and a supportive family are among the main factors that affect the chances of a criminal going on to commit more crime.

Research has shown that between 50 and 80 per cent of prisoners have writing, numeracy and reading skills below the level of an 11 year old child, and for young people in custody, three quarters have a history of regular school truancy, and two thirds have no qualifications. Offenders are 13 times more likely to be unemployed than the rest of society.

We will tackle this problem by **introducing schemes to provide offenders with skills for work, not crime**. Providing transferable skills and training to offenders, with secure employment opportunities, will be effective in cutting reoffending rates. Some successful individual schemes have shown a huge decrease in reoffending. That is why I want more schemes to help prisoners to attain the writing, numeracy and reading skills required to gain qualifications and employment, including for some offenders a tough contract of conditions associated with training and work for prisoners. One of the major measures of the effectiveness of the new SCRS will be in meeting **challenging targets for the number of prisoners leaving custody with nationally accredited qualifications**.

I want to see **Business Sector Coordinators in every prison** to maintain positive relationships with local

employers and build on existing links between prisons and employers in the community to enable prisoners, where appropriate, to participate in external work placements. And I want to work with businesses and employers' organisations to introduce a **training scheme for selected offenders in areas such as trades, construction and engineering** where Scotland has a shortage of trained workers and vacancies which are considered hard to fill. For some offenders this should include the option of relocation with employment to address habitual reoffending.

I want to use the changes that we will bring to sentencing to introduce **more tailored programmes for individual offenders** serving the remainder of their sentence in the community. That will include writing in conditions such as compulsory housing interviews, attendance at education and training classes or other services such as anger management courses. Breach of these conditions could see offenders returned to prison.

Tackling violent crime

Some communities continue to suffer a terrible toll from high levels of violent crime. Too many lives have been lost or disfigured by this culture of violence and particularly by knife crime. We want to crack down on knife crime, working with the police to **reduce the supply of knives and weapons**, with effective action to break down gang culture and the reasons behind violence.

It is important to give a clear, unambiguous signal about the seriousness of carrying a knife in Scotland. We will **introduce maximum seven year combined custody and community sentences for possession of a knife**. These sentences will be tougher, but with more focus on the reasons behind the offending to cut down on this menace. We will also continue to support the work of Scotland's police-led Violence Reduction Unit, ensuring it works seamlessly with the new Scottish Custody and Rehabilitation Service and Community Justice Authorities.

We will act to **restrict the availability of airguns in Scotland with tough licensing** on the sale of airguns,

and ensure this is rigorously policed. Violent crime is closely linked to alcohol and drug use. Government strategies for tackling alcohol misuse, domestic abuse and violent crime must come with consistent funding.

Ultimately we must do more to tackle the root causes of violent crime. The World Health Organisation has recommended that violent crime be set within a public health model. Violent crime in its causes and effects for perpetrators, victims and onlookers is a public health issue. Emerging research suggests that early development issues are linked to a propensity towards violent crime. I want to see more research on the links between violent crime and early years development.

Reducing youth crime

The vast majority of young people are not involved in youth crime. In fact, less than a tenth of one per cent of young people are persistent youth offenders, and the victims of youth crime are frequently young people themselves. That's why it is important not to demonise young people in Scotland. However, where there are problems with youth crime in an area, we believe in effective long term action to tackle the issues.

Tackling youth crime should be based on a **culture of early intervention**. Professionals in nurseries, schools, health and social work are often good at identifying young people who are at risk of developing disruptive or criminal behaviour, but we are less effective at initiating processes and procedures to do something about this behaviour at a very early stage. We will make early intervention a real priority. We will create in the Scottish Executive a **high level team to focus exclusively on best practice for early intervention** and disseminate this to local authorities, health boards and police through Community Justice Authorities.

We need to involve young people themselves to cut crime. To nip low level offending behaviour in the bud, I want to build on the effective approach in New York and **establish Youth Panels** that allow young people themselves to be



Crime and justice

involved in judging and changing the behaviour of young people before it develops further.

I also want to establish a **Scottish Youth Justice Board** to oversee the youth justice system and involve young people in shaping youth justice policy. The Board would be advisory but would report equally to the Minister for Justice and to the Parliament.

Diverting young people from crime

A recent Scottish Children's Reporter Administration report stated that "a lack of structured leisure activities was cited in social work reports as a factor contributing to offending behaviour for 59 per cent of the sample."

That is why a major focus of action to tackle antisocial behaviour by young people must be to divert more away from crime into more productive alternatives. I believe that extending youth work has an important part to play in tackling antisocial behaviour. **More 'outreach' youth work**, where workers go out to work with disengaged young people, has an important role to play.

Local initiatives to tackle antisocial behaviour should focus on engaging with young people to ensure **adequate alternative facilities are provided**. Young people themselves must be involved in the development of local antisocial behaviour strategies and this should be integrated as much as possible with the National Youth Work Strategy. We will consult on whether this is best achieved through a network of local youth work partnerships in each local authority area and will task the Youth Justice Board with developing best practice.

I want to see more successful schemes such as **midnight football, basketball leagues, youth cafes and other innovative approaches**.

We will also support the **roll out of police Youth Action Teams** which have demonstrated success in tackling hotspots of youth crime and have developed innovative methods to engage with the worst offenders.

Scottish Liberal Democrats give our strong support to the

Children's Hearings System. The Kilbrandon principles still hold true today. We will continue to support and develop the Children's Hearings system to take appropriate action against young offenders and safeguard the needs of the most vulnerable and troubled young people in Scotland.

The Children's Hearings System has seen a massive increase in the number of children referred on care and protection grounds. However, there is a growing view that many of these referrals are not appropriate. We will **increase the use of pre-screening measures** to ensure that referrals to the Children's Hearings system are appropriate, and expand the disposals and options open to Hearings. We will roll out programmes such as the Tayside Domestic Abuse Service which redirect referrals to the hearings system that can be better dealt with through other interventions.

We will continue working with children's services to deliver the Getting it Right for Every Child agenda, making sure that the right structures, systems and staff are in place to deliver the high quality services that will realise our vision for children.

Support for victims and communities

At present only victims of very serious crime are given notification of the outcome of a case. We will **extend the victim notification scheme** so victims can be informed of the results of a trial and when an offender is released to those cases where the offender has been sentenced to over one year. We will also provide resources for the police to contact more regularly those who have reported an incident or crime so they can feel more secure or track what happened.

We will **tackle the low conviction rate for rape** and improve the justice process for victims by ensuring the effective implementation of the recommendations of the Crown Office review of the prosecution of rape and serious sexual offences.

We will **evaluate the pilot of a specialist domestic abuse court. If successful, we will develop further this model for other parts of Scotland**. We will ensure **greater provision for community mediation** for neighbour, housing and antisocial disputes, including greater use of Acceptable Behaviour Contracts and increased support for diversionary activities. There should be more co-ordinated funding for family mediation and care conferencing.

We will continue to support community wardens to work alongside community policy officers and support the **roll out of taxi marshals for taxi ranks** in large towns and cities to improve safety at evenings and weekends.

Good design and architecture can have a real impact in cutting crime. We will ensure that the highest design standards are included in planning guidance to make communities safer.

Drugs, alcohol and crime

Everyone knows that there is a direct link between drug use and crime. In fact around 70 per cent of court cases in Scotland are thought to be drug related. The Scottish Executive estimates that the cost of drug related crime to the public sector alone is over £330 million per annum.

Nearly half of all violent crimes are committed under the influence of alcohol, and research shows that between 60 and 70 per cent of prisoners were using drugs before imprisonment. Many repeat offenders have significant drug problems.

Kicking the drug habit is difficult and without assistance too many addicts will continue to use drugs and fund their habit through crime. It makes sense then to do more to tackle crime and drug dependency together.

Drug Treatment and Testing Orders are community sentences that work in cutting crime and reoffending. Around half of offenders who completed DTTOs did not offend within two years - remember two thirds of prisoners go on to reoffend and that figure is higher among drug users. Of those that did reoffend, their crimes





tended to be less serious. I want to see **DTTOs rolled out to Scotland's district courts too.**

DTTOs are not often used for alcohol treatment. Yet Scotland's alcohol culture is an underlying cause of a significant amount of crime, violence and antisocial behaviour. We want to pilot specific **Alcohol Treatment and Testing Orders (ATTOs).**

Research shows that every £1 invested in drug treatment saves £3 in the cost of enforcement. That is why I want to see more people referred to treatment services and support at the point of arrest when the police know or suspect them of drug or alcohol abuse. We will **support greater use of Arrest Referral Schemes** across Scotland, with shorter waiting times and greater availability of treatment.

I will require the establishment of a **national register of drug and alcohol services**, including residential placements, to improve knowledge of availability of places

across Scotland. I will back this up with a **doubling of funding for drug and alcohol treatment - more than £100 million of extra resources over the next spending review.** This extra funding will be used to increase residential places, cut waiting times for services, and create more family support posts to provide intensive early support to prevent crises developing.

We will support **more early employability programmes which are integrated with the treatment, care and rehabilitation sectors**, to provide effective routes out from problem drug use and thus prevent queues for treatment arising from bottlenecks in the treatment system.

We will introduce a strategy, led by the Scottish Executive, for early intervention with vulnerable young people, for example those in care and those living with a parent who has a drug problem. This will include more support for family conferencing and co-ordination of social work and community services.

Alcohol is a major problem across the whole of Scottish society, but some communities report a particular problem with antisocial behaviour carried out by young people



Crime and justice

under the influence of alcohol. Our plans to tackle underage drinking with more test purchasing and proof of age are detailed in the Health section of this manifesto. We will also **introduce a national bottle marking scheme for alcohol**, allowing easy tracing to the source where alcohol was bought. Schemes in the Borders and Edinburgh have already proven successful. When young people are caught underage drinking by the police they should be able to be referred to **local alcohol referral programmes for young people**, supported by sustainable funding. We will **support alternative alcohol free activities for young people**, including more youth cafes, better enforcement of existing laws on alcohol, an emphasis on positive life choices and career opportunities for young people.

Courts

Scotland's legal system has seen a major programme of reform to update procedures and streamline processes. To continue this reform we will **develop training and support services for Justices of the Peace to ensure more coordinated provision for lay justices**. Recognising the developing role of the children's hearing system, we will support enhanced training for panel members. We will also establish a national campaign to attract young people and people from minority groups to serve as lay justices and children's panel members.

We will work to address the wider issues behind hate crimes through more education and prevention measures. We will **legislate to extend the statutory aggravation for racist and religious hate crime to cover homophobic and disability-related hate crime**.

I want to explore new ways of delivering legal services, including in court advice and mediation services based within Sheriff Courts to help reduce court time and cost by settling disputes out of court. We will **bring forward a Judiciary (Scotland) Bill** to reform the judiciary's relationship with the Court Service, building upon the "Strengthening Judicial Independence in a Modern Scotland" consultation.

We want to improve access to legal advice and assistance, targeting rural and deprived areas. This will include providing more grant assistance for accessing advice through Citizens' Advice Bureau offices. We will ensure that basic legal and financial information is taught in schools as part of the citizenship agenda.

We will **continue to reform civil law, working with the Scottish Law Commission to identify priorities for action**. We will also take forward a **review of civil courts** under the leadership of Lord Gill. We will also establish a business and judicial led Commission to consider how Scots law can be reformed to assist in the development of the economy.

Civil liberties and equality

Liberal Democrats have long fought to protect the rights and civil liberties of people in Scotland. That is why we have stopped the Labour Party from introducing an ID card compulsory for accessing public services like health or education in Scotland, and why we prevented plans to extend the powers of the police to retain indefinitely the DNA of people never charged with an offence.

We strongly believe that human rights, applied without distinction and without regard to a person's beliefs, religion, culture or politics, are the basis of social justice. When these rights are breached, we all suffer, but society's poor and powerless suffer most.

Liberal Democrats will continue to protect and enforce human rights in Scotland and ensure that the correct balance is struck between the rights of individuals and the interests of society. Having passed the legislation, we will now move quickly to establish an independent **Scottish Commission for Human Rights** to promote awareness of, and respect for, these rights in Scotland.

Equal opportunities

Mainstreaming equality across every area of government is an important agenda that must

move forward. We are committed to producing an annual report on the progress on mainstreaming equality as part of this process.

We also want to work with local authorities and other public services to develop an equality standard for Scotland which can act as a voluntary best value performance indicator.

Gender equality

It is unacceptable that in twenty-first century Scotland, women are still more likely to be poor, to have low pay jobs and to be unable to fulfil their potential. Scotland should blaze the trail in creating real equality of opportunity. If women were to reach their full potential as entrepreneurs, Scotland would have about 75,000 more businesses than it does today.

From this year public bodies in Scotland will be required to deliver equality in their work. That should mean innovative working practice to help women progress in their career, not simply comparing our workers' pay slips. We will **implement the recommendations of the Women and Work Commission in Scotland**. We will also support moves to promote more flexible working to benefit those with families.

Disability

Scottish Liberal Democrats want to see an accessible, equal Scotland for all with increased participation of disabled people in public life. We want to **support disabled people towards independent living with a user-led Centre for Independent Living in every local authority area and stronger minimum statutory requirements** for the delivery of services to disabled people in Scotland. This should include improved access to advocacy services. We will encourage local authorities to put in place Registers of Accessible Housing to ensure that best use is made of housing stock that is accessible to disabled tenants. People with disabilities face particular challenges in obtaining and keeping employment.





I want to see challenging targets set to improve the employment levels of disabled people. I want to see more voluntary sector and social enterprise involvement in getting disabled people into volunteering as a first step into work. And to encourage more disabled people to start their own businesses, we will ensure the Enterprise Agencies roll out the Business Able scheme across Scotland.

The introduction of the Disability Equality Duty (DED) in December 2006 places firm responsibilities on public services to involve disabled people in the planning and delivery of their services. It is important that public authorities use this as an opportunity to improve the provision of services to deaf / hard of hearing and blind / partially sighted people to ensure that they have access to a range of public services. This should include mainstreaming disability awareness into training for frontline public sector workers.

Racism

There is no place in modern Scotland for racism. We will continue to **support the One Scotland Many Cultures campaign** and publish a **new Race Equality Strategy and Action Plan for Scotland**. To make race equality a reality, we need the right information. Currently data collected on ethnic minorities does not reflect the full breadth of the population. That is why we will improve data collection systems to measure more accurately Scotland's ethnic diversity and trends in racial inequality.

Asylum seekers

Clearly where there are failed asylum seekers there has to be a system to remove people from the country, but dawn raids are not the right approach, especially for families with children. They are unacceptable and unnecessary. I believe that there has to be a more sensitive, integrated approach involving the education authorities, social work departments and the UK agencies when children are involved. We will continue to press the Home Office for changes to the system to recognise this.



Transport

“I am committed to a major programme of public transport investment in new rail lines, faster and longer trains, more park and ride sites, better bus services, more transport where and when you need it, better facilities for cycling and walking, and action to get more freight off the roads.”



Public transport

Liberal Democrats in government have significantly increased expenditure on vital transport infrastructure. Investment in public transport in Scotland is at record levels with 70 per cent of funding going towards public transport - a marked departure from previous governments. This new higher level of investment needs to be maintained. This will give us the opportunity to begin planning the next phase of public transport investment through the Strategic Projects Review and the National Transport Strategy to 2020.

I want to ensure that we back the right projects, delivering greater integration of transport, better use of information and communications technology, easier door to door journey planning, more use of multi-modal options such as park and ride schemes, improvements to key interchanges, better timetabling and ticketing arrangements.

And so that we can lever in more investment in transport, I want to involve the private sector in financing and delivering priority transport facilities, by **doing more to capture land value increases** brought about by public investment in infrastructure.

I want to reduce journey times, tackle congestion, and provide attractive alternatives to the private car. I want to improve connections and accessibility, at the same time as reducing the impact of transport on the environment. We need a public transport system which is attractive, efficient and affordable with proper integration and through-ticketing.

My aim is to have a world class transport system fit for the twenty-first century.

Rail and light rail

Liberal Democrats want more from rail as part of our continuing commitment to improving public transport. We have an ambitious programme of investment to reduce journey times, increase capacity, upgrade facilities, and improve the quality, reliability, safety and attractiveness of the rail network in Scotland.

I want to see more new trains for our rail network with lower emission engines. Where it makes sense we will electrify the network as part of our drive to reduce the impact transport has on our environment.

Encouraging more people to get out of their cars and take the train instead, at least for part of their journey, will mean big improvements to congestion and reductions in carbon emissions. In the past four years passenger numbers in Scotland have risen by 31 per cent. We should be ambitious. I want to see rail passenger journeys rise by a further 20 per cent by 2012 - 70 per cent higher than the final year of the Tory government.

To meet this ambitious target, I am **committed to deliver our existing major public transport commitments**, including completing the Stirling-Alloa-Kincardine line; building the Borders Railway, the Edinburgh Airport Rail Link (EARL), the Glasgow Airport Rail Link (GARL) and the Airdrie-Bathgate railway; support for the Edinburgh trams; and investment in



- 
- › **faster trains**
 - › **major new investment in public transport**
 - › **new park and ride**
 - › **better buses**



We think public transport can be better.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Transport

Transport priorities

- › **Faster trains between Scotland's cities and support a high speed link to London.**
- › **Major new investment in public transport.**
- › **Make Scotland a cycling nation.**
- › **Action to improve safety on our roads.**
- › **Replacement crossing for the Forth with better public transport.**

Edinburgh Waverley station.

To encourage people to shift from the private car to the train we must make it a more attractive choice. That is why I am committed to **reducing rail journey times between Scotland's cities** so that the train is always a faster option than the private car.

To deliver on this pledge we will cut journey times, increase capacity, reduce overcrowding, tackle major bottlenecks and improve service frequency across a number of key routes. I want people across Scotland to benefit from this investment in our railways.

In central and west Scotland we will support the electrification of a number of routes including Whifflet, Paisley Canal, East Kilbride and Barrhead/Kilmarnock, Stirling/Dunblane/Alloa, and Cumbernauld. We will invest in more frequent services and longer trains and platforms to increase capacity on services from Kilmarnock to Glasgow and on services to and from Stirling and Dunblane.

I want to see increased capacity at both Glasgow Central and Glasgow Queen Street Stations. We will work with SPT and Transport Scotland on the Glasgow Crossrail project. We will examine the potential and affordability of an extension to the Glasgow subway.

In the north and Highlands, we will give the go-ahead for the Highland Rail proposals, reducing journey times between Inverness and the central belt to under three hours - more than competitive with the private car. This will increase the frequency of the Inverness to Edinburgh service and cut journey times by around 45 minutes, including over half an hour's reduction in journey time from Perth to Edinburgh.

For people in the north east of Scotland we will increase the Inverness to Aberdeen service to an hourly service, extending platforms to allow longer trains to increase capacity in growth areas like Elgin, and increase frequency between Aberdeen and Inverurie. We will deliver a new station at Laurencekirk and support feasibility and value analysis of the Aberdeen Crossrail project. And to improve the links to the south, we will

reduce journey times on Aberdeen to Edinburgh services by at least 15 minutes.

The links between our capital and our largest city are vital to Scotland's future economic success. We will investigate the options to reduce journey times between Edinburgh and Glasgow and cut carbon emissions through electrification and improving the frequency and speed of alternative services via the Shotts and Carstairs routes. **By 2020, our ambition is for a high speed rail service between Edinburgh and Glasgow, cutting travel time to 30 minutes at most.**

For Edinburgh, Fife and the Borders, we will continue to develop Haymarket Station as a key interchange station, ensuring it integrates with the city's new tram network. We will continue the re-development of Waverley Station to increase capacity and enhance passenger access and circulation space. I want to increase capacity on Edinburgh - Fife services. We will also investigate the case for reinstating passenger rail services to Leven, including a park and ride site and the case for a new rail halt at Newburgh. We will also support further analysis of the case for the reintroduction of the South Suburban Railway in Edinburgh. We will build the Borders Railway and start planning for further extensions to the route.

We will press the UK Government to build a high speed rail link between Scotland and London, delivering sub three hour journeys - providing a highly competitive alternative that consistently beats domestic air flights to London.

This massive investment in our rail network will benefit people across Scotland. But we have to do more than build new railways and improve services, we also have to ensure that the service is attractive to passengers. That is why I am also committed to a review of fares policy on the First Scotrail franchise to encourage greater modal shift, increase use of train services at off peak times and reduce the barrier to people switching for unplanned journeys by reducing very high 'step on' fares. And to get more people to use the train for at least part of their journey, I want to see a major programme of car parking expansion at Scotland's railway stations, including more demand





responsive transport to link to rail services and remove the need to use the car at all. Part of this drive must also be to continue to improve the provision of secure cycle storage and bike capacity on trains across Scotland.

Better buses and transport when you need it

I want to see modern, reliable, safe and integrated bus services operating throughout Scotland, delivered by public and private partners working well together. Bus services are the principal form of public transport in Scotland. They have huge potential to improve journey times and connections, reduce emissions, improve quality and accessibility and tackle affordability.

I want to see all bus operators raise their standards to those of the best, using modern, efficient, low emission vehicles. I want to see reliable, punctual services, integrating with trains, trams and ferries and encouraging healthy lifestyle choices such as walking and cycling. I want to see local government invest in the high quality roads and infrastructure which a modern bus industry needs. Passengers deserve nothing less, no matter where in Scotland they use the bus.

I want to **strengthen bus quality partnerships** to cover issues such as frequency and punctuality of services. And because there has yet to be a quality contract implemented in Scotland, I believe the time is right to **simplify the process so that it is easier to move to this form of franchising**. This means that local and regional transport authorities will have greater control where they need it.

Passengers get frustrated when they arrive at a bus stop to find next to no timetable information, or find that one company's services are listed but others aren't. They don't care who is responsible, they simply want to know about all the services available to them.

To improve the service to passengers we will conduct a **nationwide review of bus stop information** to improve the availability of information and increase the use of real time bus information.

Transport

If we can use technology to improve the service to passengers on our main bus services, the opportunities for giving people access to public transport when they need it are even greater.

In many rural areas, and I believe in many urban settings too, traditional bus services simply don't make sense. They are too expensive and not flexible enough to meet people's needs. There is a better, more efficient way of meeting their transport needs than paying for empty buses to make irregular trips to places that people don't want to go to.

Demand Responsive Transport is the jargon for better transport when and where people need it.

A recent pilot scheme in Angus has shown that the technology works, with a regional call centre handling requests for transport such as taxibuses and minibuses with people able to book a time slot and pick up and drop off points. I believe that we must **increase our investment in these technologies and services** so more people benefit from flexible, low cost public transport which integrates with other services, including traditional buses.

Roads

We will **abolish tolls on the Tay Bridge and end them on the Forth Bridge for cars with more than one occupant**. We will **ensure the replacement Forth crossing is built as soon as practicable** with special provision for public transport such as light rail and bus.

We will **implement the current planned road infrastructure investment**. In assessing bids for future road projects, we will only proceed when necessary for safety reasons, to connect isolated communities or for environmental reasons when it is better to re-route traffic in the interests of cutting pollution.

Action is needed to improve a number of long distance single carriageway routes, including transnational roads. In some cases this will mean improvements to road surfaces, tackling bottlenecks, increasing safety at accident blackspots and providing

unambiguous overtaking opportunities. We will support improvements to this network. We will introduce a programme of road safety audits to prioritise improvements and require local authorities to audit the state of their roads and make a public report. **We will introduce a challenge fund to improve the state of local roads.**

We've made real progress in reducing the number of road casualties, but there is more to do. In 2005 368 children were killed or seriously injured in road accidents. That is an unacceptable loss of life. **My long term aspiration is for no child to be killed on Scotland's roads.**

In 1997 the Swedish Government launched its 'Vision Zero' policy stating that any road deaths were unacceptable. We will consult on what lessons Scotland can learn from this approach. We will **extend the Pass Plus scheme across Scotland** to support young drivers to take advanced driver training to improve their skills.

Choose cycling and walking

Air pollution contributes to more than 2,000 deaths in Scotland every year and exacerbates asthma and other respiratory problems.

Promoting health and wellbeing should be a key objective of Scotland's transport system, getting people out of cars and on to more sustainable transport.

There is a major challenge in addressing the issue of the school run. I want to see **bold targets for more children going to school by public transport, cycling or walking** as part of a comprehensive **school run policy**. **I want to see year on year decreases in children going to school by car. This will include a pilot of new stricter restrictions on cars outside schools**, better cycle training, safer routes to school and secure cycle storage. We will work with parents' councils to develop school transport plans and continue funding for School Travel Plan coordinators. We will ensure that 20mph speed limit zones are in operation around all

schools and encourage the rapid roll out of 20mph speed limit zones in residential areas.

I want to make Scotland a cycling nation, making it safer and easier for people to cycle and walk for more of the common journeys they make. I will set a **target to double cycling rates in Scotland by 2012**.

To make Scotland a cycling nation, we will start with a **new Cycling Demonstration Town Fund**. This will invest in cycle paths, road improvements and cycling facilities to increase significantly cycling rates. Regional Transport Partnerships will be required to promote cycling in their strategies with ambitious targets to increase the proportion of journeys made by bicycle. There are many reasons why people don't cycle to work, but for some it just isn't a realistic option because of a lack of facilities.

Large employers in particular need to be encouraged to do more to support cycling, but smaller businesses will always struggle. That's why I want to **pilot Cycle Resource Centres** in town and city centres. These Centres will provide secure cycle storage, lockers, showers, changing areas, access to advice on routes and maps, and bike maintenance and repair services. We will support increased investment in safe segregated cycle paths, requiring major towns and cities to develop a core network of routes from residential areas to town centres, linking in to Cycle Resource Centres.

We will work with Cycling Scotland to investigate the opportunities for an annual 'Tour of Scotland' cycle race to promote cycling across Scotland.

Freight

I want to reduce the impact of freight by getting more freight off the roads and on to more sustainable routes. We have already been successful in removing 26 million lorry miles from Scotland's roads but I believe we can do more through the **Scottish freight strategy** to support the Scottish haulage industry to get more freight off the roads and on to rail, sea and waterways. This will mean increasing support through Freight Facilities Grants,



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- A silhouette of a person riding a bicycle is positioned on the right side of the frame. The person is wearing a helmet and is captured in a side profile, facing left. The bicycle is a standard road or hybrid bike. The background is a dramatic, low-angle shot of a sunset or sunrise, with a bright sun partially obscured by the front wheel of the bicycle, creating a strong lens flare and illuminating the sky in shades of orange and yellow. The overall mood is inspiring and active.
- › **Cycling Demonstration Town Fund**
 - › **more segregated cycle paths**
 - › **Cycle Resource Centres**
 - › **tackle the school run**



We think Scotland can be a cycling nation.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Transport

Waterborne Freight Grants and the Strategic Timber Fund, including more support for small and medium enterprises seeking freight grants.

A number of European cities like Stockholm and Toulouse have taken action to reduce the environmental and social impacts of heavy freight in town and city centres through the use of **freight consolidation centres (FCCs)**. This model works to reduce empty running, consolidate loads and encourage the use of smaller, more environmentally friendly delivery vehicles at appropriate times in built up urban areas. I want to work with business and the freight industry to develop a plan to pilot an FCC in Scotland and introduce **Freight Quality Partnerships**.

Our massive investment in Scotland's railways will also extend to support more rail freight, delivering the Stirling-Alloa-Kincardine line and considering the feasibility of enhancing capacity on the Glasgow and South Western route to assist freight movements.

We **support the development of container terminals at Hunterston and Scapa Flow** to create international shipping hubs and we will consider the options for development of the deep water ports at Greenock and Grangemouth.

Air

The **Air Route Development Fund** has been a real success, opening up new markets to Scotland and replacing the need to take two flights through increasingly congested hubs in the south of England.

We will continue to refine the fund to ensure direct air links to key markets, providing it helps to establish a regular service and does not support a cheap flight service where rail alternatives exist. As the Fund develops it will focus increasingly on marketing support. We will press for a high speed rail link to London as a means to reduce demand for internal flights.

Ferries and lifeline links

We will evaluate the trial of the fast ferry across the Forth and support the development of the infrastructure necessary to make the plans a reality, increasing the travel options for commuters travelling to and from Edinburgh.

Our island and remote communities depend on ferry and lifeline links. We want to improve further lifeline ferries and flights to the Highlands and Islands by examining the **extension of our 40 per cent air discount scheme to ferries** and carrying out a review of CalMac ferry fares to provide more affordable fares for islanders.

We will also improve freight requirements for businesses and communities in the Highlands and Islands through targeted enhancements and revised fare structures as part of the next tender period for lifeline ferry services.

Reducing the impact of transport

We'll never truly tackle climate change if we don't address the issue of carbon emissions and energy use from transport. That is why in addition to action to increase the use of public transport, cycling and walking, we also want to do more to introduce cleaner fuels and get more people to travel sustainably.

We will not introduce road user charging in Scotland. Should the UK Labour Government introduce road charging, we would only consider supporting it if existing vehicle excise duty and fuel duty are abolished to make the system tax neutral.

Every major travel generator, such as shopping centres, hospitals, business parks and major tourist destinations, should develop a **sustainable transport plan** in association with local authorities and regional transport partnerships. Councils should be given powers to fine organisations that fail to comply and work to get more people out of their cars.

The **public sector** will take a lead, ensuring that **sustainable transport plans are in place by 2009** at the latest for significant public sector facilities.

All businesses must have access to the next generation of broadband technology. Both the public and the private sector need to make best use of this technology **to promote more flexible and home working**. Embracing this technology will reduce congestion and have major environmental benefits.

I also want to promote the development of **cleaner fuels and vehicles**. This is primarily a matter for the UK Government, but I believe that the Scottish Executive can give political impetus and support. We will transfer the existing funding support for diesel buses to support for more sustainable, less polluting fuels.

I want to increase the use of renewable energy in transport, including piloting the potential of electric transport to help reduce air pollution and improve air quality.

We will also lobby the UK Government for the speedy implementation of the renewable transport fuels obligation and additional fuel duty incentives for alternative fuels. I also believe that Scotland has the potential to benefit greatly from the development of hydrogen technology.

As part of our wider drive to reduce carbon emissions, we will introduce a **'carbon balance sheet' for transport** which will present the impact of all Scottish transport policies and projects that are expected to have a significant impact on carbon, whether positive or negative.

We will **press for international agreement for aviation to pay its full environmental costs, while protecting lifeline air links**. We support the application of the EU Emissions Trading Scheme to air transport with exemptions only for essential lifeline services to Scotland's remote and island communities.





Rural development

“Rural Scotland is a jewel in Scotland’s crown, providing the high quality food, glorious landscape, leisure opportunities and celebrated heritage that is central to the way our country is perceived and marketed around the world.”



Rural Scotland

Scottish Liberal Democrats believe that preserving and enhancing Scotland’s rural areas and natural heritage is vital to Scotland’s economic and social wellbeing.

Rural Scotland faces a number of challenges. I recognise the central role of farming, fishing and forestry in the rural economy. I want to tackle rural poverty, encouraging new businesses to set up and develop in rural Scotland. Retaining young people in, and attracting inward migration to, rural communities to help maintain a balanced population and sustainable communities with access to quality public services is crucial. That also means increasing the availability of business premises for new enterprises and land for affordable housing.

I want to ensure that rural Scotland benefits from the huge potential which lies in making Scotland the renewables powerhouse of Europe, with new jobs, industries and income streams. And I think that there is a major opportunity to develop markets for quality Scottish produce at home and for export.

Rural economy

I want to see a vibrant and sustainable rural economy. I will continue to support the work of the Enterprise networks and take action to ensure that the government recognises the needs of rural Scotland.

I want to see **all policy and legislation ‘rural-proofed’**

for its impact on rural areas. Improving transport links to rural areas is important, as is ensuring that the right communications infrastructure is in place.

I want to build on progress and roll out **faster broadband connections across rural areas**, including use of satellite broadband and piloting local fibre-optic networks. To reverse the loss of people from rural areas in search of employment in urban areas we must look to greater use of information technology to encourage more remote working, allowing people to live and work from rural areas without having to commute to urban areas. That’s why we will support a **network of Remote Worker Centres** in rural areas.

Scottish Liberal Democrats recognise the importance of tourism in Scotland’s rural areas. **We want to support the industry to meet its ambitious target to grow Scottish tourism by 50 per cent by 2015.** And because it is important that growth in tourism is sustainable, we will support an **expansion of the Green Tourism Business Scheme** to reward those businesses that rise to the green tourism challenge.

Scotland can also do more to expand the role in the rural economy of tourism and leisure opportunities such as freshwater angling, field and country sports, and outdoor activities.

Sustaining public services in rural areas can be challenging but is often vital to the sustainability of the community itself. I want to see more co-location and shared services in rural areas. We will provide funding for a **programme**





We think rural Scotland matters.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Rural development

Rural priorities

- › **New Scottish Food and Drink promotion body.**
- › **Community Land Trusts to support more affordable housing.**
- › **Sustain public services with more co-location and shared services.**
- › **Increase the use of local Scottish produce across the public sector.**
- › **Reforestation and biomass.**
- › **Cut red tape and bureaucracy in agriculture.**

of investment in local community halls and facilities to act as wider community hubs for a range of services, helping to sustain services including a **rural post office network**.

Scottish Liberal Democrats recognise the rising cost of fuel in Scotland's most rural and remote areas. We will **lobby the UK Government to take action by reducing fuel duty in specific zones of rural Scotland**.

If we are to sustain rural communities across Scotland we must tackle the growing issue of access to affordable housing. We will deliver an additional 9,000 affordable homes for rent and sale across Scotland each year.

I want to support an innovative scheme first pursued in the USA by American civil rights campaigner Dr Martin Luther King. **Community Land Trusts** empower local people to take action for themselves to meet local housing needs. By taking ownership of the land, communities are also able to come together to provide a range of affordable housing options, including housing for rent, shared equity, and mutual home ownership schemes. We will encourage local authorities and public agencies to make more land available for affordable housing and set up a new fund to support communities to take advantage of this approach.

And as part of our approach to improve the availability of affordable housing in rural areas, we will **encourage and promote the conversion of redundant farm buildings and cottages, making it easier to develop redundant farm land for affordable housing**. We will also pilot "unplugged" houses, using microgeneration, recycling grey water and other environmental technologies to develop houses with reduced dependence on mains infrastructure. More information on our housing policies can be found in the Communities section.

Agriculture

Better regulation

Agriculture continues to play a central role in the rural economy. I want to **establish a Better Regulation Group** - involving key players from the industry - to assess all new regulations to ensure the optimum simplicity of

implementation at the lowest cost burden.

They will be tasked with eliminating unnecessary paperwork, inspections and impractical procedures. **Where new regulations are brought in, I will ask for their recommendations on revoking existing regulations that are rendered redundant.** Over time I will ask them to consider progressively existing regulations and consult widely within the industry to tackle the most unnecessary first.

It simply isn't fair that some farmers and crofters suffer heavy penalties for simple administrative errors when applying for agricultural subsidies. That is why we are committed to **campaign for the European Union to categorise errors in applications as obvious, administrative or negligent and to specify penalties that are proportionate** to the level of error within each category.

New entrants to farming

I want to **support new entrants to farming**. This is not a simple matter that can be solved overnight, but there is action that we must take. We will **review the Agricultural Holdings Act** to ensure it is providing sufficient opportunities for new tenants and take further action if necessary. We will work with farmers' groups to develop opportunities for new entrants, considering options such as mixed equity schemes and planning exemptions for retiring farmers to build new homes on the land. We will provide support within the Land Management Contracts (LMC) menu to assist new entrants with business training and support, the modernisation and repair of buildings, and the provision or upgrading of infrastructure.

Agriculture support

Scottish Liberal Democrats want to **regionalise the assessment and distribution of agri-environmental schemes and support programmes**. And we will ensure that the new Less Favoured Areas Support Scheme **compensates crofters and farmers in the Islands**





Rural development

and outlying rural areas for the extra costs of transport and haulage. We will continue government support for the wider public benefits of agricultural activity, such as maintaining the landscape and natural heritage and supporting the wider rural economy, up to and beyond 2013. We will **renegotiate Scotland's allocation of rural funding at EU level to give Scotland its fair share** as part of the forthcoming review in 2009.

We want to **support Scotland's crofters** to ensure a secure future for crofting with greater accountability and democratisation of the Crofters Commission, implementing the recommendations of the Crofter's Inquiry following its completion at the end of 2007.

And to support our dairy farmers, we will **campaign for changes at Westminster to remove the unfair restrictions that limit the size of milk co-operatives**, and permit Scottish dairy farmers to benefit from a move into value added products.

As part of the drive to ensure that rural Scotland benefits from Scotland becoming the renewable energy powerhouse of Europe, it is vital that our agriculture industry rises to the challenge. We will **support the growing of energy crops** and the use of rendered material for biofuel production, short term coppice rotation to augment local biomass heat projects, and the processing of agricultural slurry and other wastes in anaerobic digestors as fuel for local heat projects. Scotland must offer sustainable sources of biofuels.

Fisheries

Scotland's fishing industry is recognised for its high quality products. I want to do more to promote Scottish fish and seafood and will task a **new Scottish Food and Drink marketing and promotion body** with improving the market opportunities. We will **continue to drive forward regionalisation of the Common Fisheries Policy** with increased powers to Regional Advisory

Councils. We will ensure the Cod Recovery Plan not only takes account of the science but also takes account of Scotland's mixed fishery. We will also seek to reform the conduct of the EU-Norway negotiations to make the process more open and transparent.

Scottish Liberal Democrats want to **increase local control over fisheries**, including continuing to press Westminster for the **transfer of powers over the seabed from the Crown Estate** to local authorities.

We support the development of a sustainable aquaculture industry diversifying into new species. It is important that we ensure that regulation of the industry is proportionate to risk.

To recognise the importance of Scotland's marine resources, we will **introduce a Scottish Marine Bill** to provide a coherent framework for managing our seas, including measures for marine spatial planning, conservation and sea fisheries.

Powers over the marine environment are currently a mix of devolved and reserved areas. In bringing forward the Scottish Marine Bill, we will **seek the agreement of Westminster for the Scottish Parliament to have exclusive jurisdiction out to the 200 mile limit** over marine spatial planning and marine conservation, building on its current powers over sea fisheries and offshore renewable energy.

We will also build on the wide support, in principle, for a **coastal and marine national park** by consulting widely with community and sectoral interest groups on the most appropriate location and form of governance.

Quality food

Agriculture and fisheries must be able to work more closely with food and drink industries to develop markets and educate consumers about food choices. All parts of the industry - producers, processors, the food service sector and retailers - have to work together,

communicating with consumers, responding to shifts in consumer demand and making better use of marketing and branding. That is why I want to **support the establishment of a private sector-led Scottish Food and Drink marketing and promotion body** with public sector support.

I want the new body to emulate the success of Bord Bia (the Irish Food Board) in promoting Irish products. I expect the new body to become the main driver in the promotion of indigenous food and drink, plugging the information gap between the primary producer, the processor and the retailer. It should have a role in developing export markets for Scottish food and drink companies to promote Scottish produce worldwide.

Of course, we also want to promote Scottish produce at home. I welcome recent moves by certain retailers to increase the percentage of local food in their stores and we will **work with retailers to promote more use of local, Scottish produce** in stores across Scotland.

The public sector can take a real lead in promoting local food. I want to **bring more healthy local produce to Scotland's schools** by rolling out the East Ayrshire school meals pilot across Scotland. This will provide new opportunities for Scottish food producers to supply fresh, high quality, seasonal produce for school meals. I want to see similar action across the public sector with **new requirements to encourage small local suppliers to bid for more public sector contracts** by specifying requirements for freshness, delivery frequency, specific varieties and production standards.

The Scottish Parliament itself can do more, ensuring that it champions and promotes Scottish food by ensuring that the bulk of the produce sold in its restaurants and cafes is Scottish. And to build on the success of the Business in the Parliament event, I want to see a **Scottish Food in the Parliament event** to showcase Scottish produce and improve the dialogue between all aspects of the food and drink industry and Scotland's politicians.





We will **assist Scotland's burgeoning organic sector** and local producers to develop the marketing and branding of their produce to increase consumer demand. I want to work with retailers to **increase information on food miles**, allowing consumers to take decisions based on the environmental impact of food production. In the longer term we will lobby the EU to change public procurement rules to recognise the importance of reducing food miles.

I also want young people to learn more about where food comes from. That is why we will **support the work of the Royal Highland Educational Trust**.

Forestry

Forests and woodlands are important to Scotland of themselves, and should be seen as an integral part of our landscapes and land use. Forests should not be seen as something separate from farming, crofting, estate management and communities in both rural and urban areas. We will direct grant funding to this end and, in particular, aim to **support increased reforestation with native species**.

Biomass in its many forms has the potential to make a key contribution to our renewable energy and climate change objectives. Studies suggest that biomass could deliver around 450MW of electricity in Scotland.

We will **deliver a Biomass Action Plan**, ensuring that it gives strong leadership and puts in place the right framework to deliver an ambitious programme of expansion in the biomass sector in Scotland.

We will **promote a major expansion in Combined Heat and Power (CHP)**. It is important that Scotland offers sustainable sources of biofuels to support the industry rather than allow unsustainable imports like palm oil to meet the renewable fuel obligation. I also want to tackle regulations that limit our ability to meet our ambitious biomass plans.

Communities

“I’m passionate about empowering people and communities. I want to unlock the creativity, energy and enthusiasm of people in communities across Scotland. I want to see real community power, tackling poverty, building opportunity, making a real difference. It is time to put trust in people.”



Community Power

I was one of the thousands of people who took to the streets of Edinburgh in July 2005 to add my voice to the campaign to *Make Poverty History*. I was struck by the passion, the commitment and the desire of so many thousands of people who wanted to make change happen. They were prepared to go out and push and push until global leaders listened and acted. Just think of the power of that community of people, then apply that to the challenges in Scotland in our everyday lives. People can make the difference, locally and globally.

But the life chances and hopes of far too many of our fellow citizens are stunted from the beginning by lack of opportunity. To me, as a Liberal Democrat, this is a scandal. The sense of powerlessness that comes with thinking that you have no choices, that you don't have the capacity to change your life, that you can't influence what happens in your community, has an inevitable consequence – powerlessness can soon become hopelessness.

Research in Sweden shows that there's a strong link between the 'power to influence' and good health.

I strongly believe that restoring a human scale, a sense of place and values, to our lives is a substantial part of the answer to these stubborn challenges.

My aim is a freer and fairer Scotland, in which fundamental civil liberties are respected, local people are empowered and local communities and neighbourhoods thrive.

Volunteering and the voluntary sector

Every single day, people across Scotland do their bit through volunteering. Too much of it goes unnoticed. Yet these are the people who make things happen. I know that we can do much more if we put our trust in local people and give them the chance. The economic, social and cultural value of volunteering is clear and we want to support volunteering in all its forms. We will **build on the National Volunteering Strategy** and develop local strategies in partnership with the voluntary sector. And we will take action to break down the barriers to volunteering.

We will review how we can give more focused support to **build capacity** in key areas of the voluntary sector particularly for local sports, cultural and youth organisations and clubs.

I want to see a **revitalised Compact between local government and the voluntary sector**, which recognises the need for stable funding, the importance of

the voluntary sector and its growing potential to help deliver flexible public services with a human face.

Community regeneration

I want to see government, business and local people pulling together to regenerate communities. I want to see more innovative local funding vehicles to lever in additional



- 
- › trust in local people
 - › more community ownership
 - › help people to help themselves
 - › regenerate communities

freedom



We think local potential should be unlocked.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Communities

Communities priorities

- › **More affordable housing for sale and rent.**
- › **Small towns regeneration fund.**
- › **Scrap council tax and replace with a fairer local income tax based on ability to pay.**
- › **Support for small independent shops.**
- › **Tackle child poverty.**

private investment and work towards a **National Regeneration Fund**, creating a joint venture partnership between the public sector and private sector to support infrastructure costs, land remediation, mixed use developments and environmental improvements.

We will **support the roll out of Business Improvement Districts** and encourage local authorities to grow their economy by allowing them to retain all business rate receipts generated above a target and trend rather than surrender them to the central pool. To encourage the best use of local resources, we will **consult on removing or reducing empty property rates relief** with local authorities able to keep the proceeds of any additional revenue.

Towns, suburbs, and public spaces

It is time to bring renewed life and purpose back to Scotland's small towns and suburban centres. I believe we need to invest in local neighbourhoods and breathe new life into towns, burghs and communities.

Small businesses are the lifeblood of many of Scotland's communities. Yet we increasingly see small independent shops moving out of towns and suburban centres, leading to the 'ghost town' and 'clone town' phenomena. A small number of multinational stores control an increasing share of the market, and local traders are often damaged as a result.

I believe we need to tilt the balance much more in favour of small retailers and established centres. I will introduce a **Small Retailers Support Fund**. This will allow local authorities to extend discretionary rates relief to 100 per cent for small, independent shops designated as having a vital community benefit. This will build on the existing discretionary relief available in rural areas. In addition to our plans to **double small business rates relief**, this will offer real support to smaller shops. I believe we need to invest in our small towns, with a **regeneration fund to breathe new life into small towns**.

We seem to have lost the knack of creating great shared public space – places that bring people together rather

than segregate, exclude or drive them apart. By empowering people to initiate improvements to their local neighbourhoods place by place, we can invigorate our communities. These small steps to enliven streets, parks, and other public spaces are the building blocks of a thriving community.

In the end the small steps will add up to major strides. Of course it's still important to take a strategic view, to have a masterplan for a city or a region. But the danger is that this will always become a centralised approach unless it's matched by action at the very local level, place by place, street by street. I want to see local people given the power to decide what happens in and around their streets.

Safer communities

I want to build public confidence in the safety of our communities. I will **pilot the idea of a Neighbourhood Standard** where local communities are empowered to look for high standards of design, safety and support in their local city, town or suburban centres, supported by neighbourhood wardens. I want to see community street audits of key walking routes to schools, shops and public transport access points to provide an effective driver for safe roads and pavements, especially for the elderly or disabled or parents with prams. Our built environment must be suitable for people with disabilities, with street furniture provided on a 'Design for All' basis, accessible kerbs at necessary points, and a major effort to tackle parking on pavements.

Greenspace

People understand that it's important to invest in our National Health Service. It's time that government understood that it's also important to **invest in our Natural Health Service - our greenspaces**. We need to do more to recognise the links between greenspace, activity and good health. Every day new research tells us more about the links between them. Again it's commonsense to most people, but we now know that older





people who take walks around high quality greenspace near their homes can see their life expectancy increase by years. 40 per cent of people in urban areas think the quality of their greenspace has deteriorated in the last five years. In deprived areas, the figure is almost 49 per cent. How can we protect our greenspaces and improve them when we don't even keep a register of where and what they are? It's time we did.

Let's start by **putting in place a legislative presumption against the sale of urban greenspace and playing fields for development.** In the limited cases where sales are allowed they must demonstrate an overall benefit to the community. Every single penny from those sales should go to improving local greenspace and expanding activity opportunities. Playing fields must not be sold to fund other council budgets.

I want to see Scotland's towns and cities create major new parks, with high quality facilities, not broken swings or closed cafes.

Community power to decide

The introduction of fair votes for councils in May 2007 offers a real opportunity to reinvigorate local government and local communities - an opportunity we can't afford to miss. I want to see strong, effective and efficient local councils with an independent local mandate, but councils, in turn, should empower local communities to run their own village, town or suburban areas.

I want to see new models of community management. Where local people have the vision, drive and commitment to manage our public spaces, we should encourage that.

I want to see the opportunity for communities to manage local libraries, parks, sports facilities and other spaces and services where local people want it. This new model would see local people form appropriate management bodies responsible for day-to-day running, with their own devolved budget, but remaining within the strategic control of the principal local authority. These locally managed



Communities

projects will still have access to the expertise of professional officers from local authorities and other government bodies, but they will involve and engage communities in a way that no amount of consultation by institutions can.

Equally, councils and communities must decide how they want to address local needs. In some cases, public services might be passed to social enterprises, the voluntary sector or co-operatives, with a clear remit to ensure public engagement in their work.

In some areas a community council might have the right to take on functions from the local council, with the opportunity for councils to work together on joint commissioning. In other areas it might mean more use of area committees, made up of councillors for a particular community, which would handle local government functions for that community. We will create **a right in local communities to require the establishment of a Burgh Council, Community Trust or similar body in their local area.**

I also want to see local people take ownership of public space and land. In rural areas we have seen the regenerative effect that community right to buy has had in some of our most fragile communities. Yet right to buy is not just for rural areas. I want to see councils and communities working together on this. **Where a council can't demonstrate a coherent strategy to use land in its ownership for community benefit, it should be encouraged to transfer the ownership to community groups.**

In Scotland we have a long history of recognising the common good of shared public spaces and buildings for communities. Yet the stewardship of common good funds has frequently been unsatisfactory and unaccountable.

I want to **see a new Common Good Act**, to regulate, protect and modernise the framework for land, property or funds to be held in trust for the local community, and allowing the revitalisation of common good funds where local people can have access to money to regenerate local communities and spaces. This form of community funding

could play a real role in empowering local communities and could provide a new outlet for the next generation of benefactors and social entrepreneurs, as well as a mechanism for supporting the voluntary sector more effectively.

Across the country there are some excellent examples of communities and neighbourhoods coming together to change their environment, yet too often they face major challenges. I want to give them more support. Research has shown that to empower these groups, the thing they often need is 'light touch' support. Access to advisors, mediators, other groups with experience, being part of a network of community groups – these can all make a big difference. I want to **introduce a new 'light touch' programme to help engage communities and give them the power to influence events in their area.**

And to back up the community planning process and encourage agencies to work together I want to **introduce local spending plans** which set out the details of all government spending in a local authority area by all public agencies, local or national, to include an open budget meeting process to involve local people in prioritising local spending, and to consider how this can be integrated into the Scottish Parliament budget process.

This is just part of the Scottish Liberal Democrat agenda for regenerating communities. Regenerating communities also means tackling poverty and improving housing.

Housing

We recognise that a good home is the foundation of wellbeing for Scotland's people and we are committed to driving forward progress towards the Scottish Housing Quality Standard. With house prices in Scotland having risen to the point where average earners now need mortgages of more than four times their income, the need for affordable housing is greater than ever.

I believe the time is right for a national review of housing policy to agree the priorities and the way forward for the next 20 years. We are **committed to meeting the**

2012 target to abolish unintentional homelessness.

As part of the Scottish Executive the Scottish Liberal Democrats have improved levels of investment in affordable housing. At present we are delivering over 16,500 socially rented homes to improve access and choice for both the homeless and those on housing waiting lists. This is in addition to the 5,000 homes we are making available through low cost home ownership schemes.

Homestake is a scheme for first time buyers and those on low incomes who want to buy their own home but can't afford to pay the full price. It works by allowing people to take at least a 51 per cent stake (but typically 60 to 80 per cent) in the property with the remainder of the equity held by a registered social landlord. In the next spending review we will **double the resources available to Homestake** in addition to rolling out the 'open market' Homestake to allow people to buy homes on the market for general sale.

We will continue our investment in affordable housing to **deliver an additional 9,000 new affordable homes for rent and sale each year** - an extra 27,000 homes over the period of the next spending review.

Rising prices are making it increasingly difficult for young people, and those on low and middle incomes, to achieve their aspirations of buying their first home. To increase the availability of affordable housing I want to support an innovative scheme first pursued in the USA by American civil rights campaigner Dr Martin Luther King.

Community Land Trusts empower local people to take action for themselves to meet local housing needs. By taking ownership of the land, communities are also able to come together to provide a range of affordable housing options, including housing for rent, shared equity, and mutual home ownership schemes.

We will encourage local authorities and public agencies to make more land available for affordable housing and set up a new fund to support communities to take advantage of this approach. And as part of our approach to improve the availability of affordable housing in rural areas, we will **encourage and promote the conversion of redundant farm buildings and cottages, making it**





- › **27,000 new affordable homes**
- › **Community Land Trusts**
- › **help for first time buyers**
- › **Healthy Green Homes Fund**



We think everyone deserves a warm dry home.

Scottish Liberal Democrats.

Communities

easier to develop redundant farm land for affordable housing. We will also pilot "unplugged" houses, using microgeneration, recycling grey water and other environmental technologies to develop houses with reduced dependence on mains infrastructure.

We want to give local authorities more power to take decisions suited to the housing conditions in their area. We will amend the current Pressurised Area Status (PAS) and Right to Buy (RTB) laws to give local authorities more flexibility. Under our plans, local authorities will no longer have to apply to Scottish Ministers to designate an area as a pressurised area. Instead we will introduce a notification process allowing Ministers a power of call-in if they are concerned at proposals put forward by a local authority. These new powers for local authorities will make it easier to introduce PAS and will allow them to apply it to more distinct geographic areas.

We will give local authorities the power to apply PAS to specific types of housing such as three, four and five bedroom homes where there are often acute shortages in supply. We will also consider the case for more local autonomy in reducing RTB discounts.

We also want to investigate the options for local authorities and social landlords to lever in new funding to increase the supply of affordable housing for rent. We will consult on the options for introducing a 'right to sell' whereby social housing could be part financed by the sale of a specified number of units in a new build on the open market.

We recognise the essential role that private landlords play in the housing market, with around 10 per cent of households in Scotland in this growing sector. The private sector plays a vital role in meeting the housing needs of people who choose not to buy a home or whose circumstances will not allow them to do so.

We want to strike a balance between the need for minimum standards, and overly burdensome bureaucratic regulations. We will **review the implementation of the landlord registration scheme** and continue to support

homeowners for the repair and maintenance of their homes. To protect people who rent in the private sector we will introduce a mandatory **national rent deposit scheme**.

Scottish Liberal Democrats believe that improving the standard of housing and reducing fuel poverty are important objectives for the next term of the Scottish Parliament. In the environment section of this manifesto we set out our ambitious plans for a healthy green homes fund to upgrade 40,000 homes a year, targeted particularly at low income households.

Tackling poverty

Scotland has made real progress in tackling poverty, with the number of children and pensioners living in poverty reduced from 1999. However, the numbers of children living in poverty in Scotland remains a national disgrace.

Tackling poverty requires concerted action in a wide range of policy areas - there is no magic bullet. To help develop a consensus on tackling poverty in the next Scottish Parliament, we will **establish a cross-party working group, involving people affected by poverty and their organisations, to explore and address the causes and effects of poverty and wealth inequality in Scotland.**

I am determined to do more to help people to help themselves. Throughout this manifesto are a number of policies that will do just that. I have already set out how I want to tackle fuel poverty and improve the environment with a major expansion in energy efficiency and microgeneration support for low income households.

I have set out how we can improve the skills of young people and tackle the issue of the high numbers of young people not in education, employment or training (NEET). I outlined how early intervention and support for early years education can have a major impact throughout life and set out our plans to improve local health services and tackle inequalities in health.

In the Crime and justice section of this manifesto I set out tough proposals to cut the crime that impacts disproportionately on people in poverty. And in this section I set out our plans to improve the availability of affordable housing and cut tax bills for those from low income households.

I believe that we need to do more to help people to help themselves out of poverty. The founder of the Subway restaurants franchise started his business with a small loan of \$1,000 - it is now a billion dollar business. That's why I want Scotland to be the first country in Europe to introduce pioneering micro-credit schemes similar to the successful projects in New York which grew out of Nobel Prize winner Muhammed Yunus's Grameen Bank. I will introduce a **Project Enterprise scheme** for Scotland to provide micro-credit, business support, advice and training to people from low income backgrounds to help them to lift themselves out of poverty and break the cycle.

Services for citizens

Community power is also about making public services and government work for citizens. I hear too many examples from people who have been sent from pillar to post with no one taking responsibility for solving their problems. People aren't interested in whose responsibility it is – they care about getting it sorted.

I want to break down institutional barriers wherever they frustrate progress or inconvenience the public. That means organisations working together across boundaries to solve people's problems.

I want to launch a new **Service Scotland** agenda to develop a one stop shop culture in Scotland's public services. This new approach will build on work to modernise government and bring the state into the information age. This will be a major culture change. When a citizen comes into contact with the state, there should be a duty on public employees to solve the problem for them, not pass them from one department to another.



We can learn lessons from the experience of the Service Canada Initiative to make the state work for citizens. I want to **launch a four year programme of reform to encourage joint working, improve access to information, and reduce bureaucracy.**

The one stop shop approach to public services needs to be reflected in communities across Scotland. It's a fact of life that the long term sustainability of some community services is linked to better integration. I want to plan a twenty-first century future for local services. Wherever possible we should see a range of public services being co-located on single sites in local communities across Scotland.

Local taxation

The council tax is an unfair system that penalises those on low incomes. The poorest 20 per cent of the population pay more of their income in council tax than the richest. Under Labour's plans for rebanding things would get worse, with one study saying that half of households would see their bills rise. People living in homes and areas where house prices have risen significantly since 1991 would also be hit hard by a council tax revaluation just as happened under Labour's revaluation in Wales.

We want to scrap the unfair council tax and replace it with a fairer local income tax based on the ability to pay. Under our plans 70 per cent of households in Scotland will be better off and most pensioner households will pay nothing. The average household in a Band D home would save hundreds of pounds a year – in fact more than 80 per cent of Band D households would pay less. The average LIT rate in Scotland would be 3.5 to 3.75 per cent. We would seek to introduce a local income tax from 2009/10.

Older people

In the first two terms of the Scottish Parliament we delivered a number of key projects of benefit to older

people in Scotland including free personal care, free nationwide bus travel, and the free central heating programme. In the next term we want to build on this progress.

I want to start by **reviewing the free personal care settlement to ensure that the next spending review is used to address issues of differential implementation across Scotland.** There must be consistency in applying this flagship policy.

Our community health agenda will bring real benefits for older people, allowing more care in their own home and locally in community health centres and community hospitals. A more personalised approach to care will be used to prevent unnecessary emergency admissions. We have to recognise the challenges and opportunities from demographic change.

We are **committed to implementing and delivering on the initiatives in the new Strategy for an Ageing Population.** This will bring together action to recognise the contribution that older people can make, their role in work and volunteering. It will also address issues including access to services, health and wellbeing, housing, transport and communities. This will underline our commitment to tackling ageism and getting older people more involved in the decisions that affect them.

We will encourage the formation of **local forums for older people** to have a say on services in their area, with more engagement from local officials. We will also support an **Annual Older People's Assembly in the Scottish Parliament.**

In the environment section of this manifesto we outline our plans to improve the thermal efficiency of Scotland's homes and introduce a new Healthy Green Homes Fund to extend the availability of microrenewables as part of our drive to eliminate fuel poverty.

Too few young people are in regular contact with older people. This can cause misunderstanding, lack of trust, and in some cases fear among older people. I will support projects that encourage more intergenerational contact through schools, volunteering and beyond. One area where this can work is encouraging young people to

volunteer to help older people in need with DIY or gardening. And of course a great many older people themselves can benefit from volunteering.

The Ageing Population Strategy must also address the issues of the 50 to 65 age group. More flexible working and lifeplanning is important. We must also improve opportunities for the 50 to 65s to remain economically active, perhaps through starting their own business or social enterprises. We will introduce a pilot scheme to support new pathways into enterprise for this group.

Our plans to scrap the unfair council tax and replace it with a fairer local income tax based on the ability to pay will be a major benefit to most older people. Most pensioner households in Scotland will pay nothing under our system.

These are just some of the ways that Scottish Liberal Democrats want to make life easier for older people.



Sport, culture and tourism

“ I am ambitious for sport in Scotland. I want to give grassroots sport a real boost and give strong backing to elite sport too starting with bringing the Commonwealth Games to Glasgow in 2014. We have a lot to be proud of in culture and tourism in Scotland and I want to build on our success.”



Sport

We will give our full support to the 2014 bid to bring the Commonwealth Games to Glasgow and ensure that the benefits are spread across Scotland. The Commonwealth Games and the London Olympics in 2012 are a superb opportunity to boost interest and participation in sport and physical activity on a permanent basis, with major benefits to the health and wellbeing of our people.

Our sports clubs are a major under-used resource. We must do more to grow them and place them at the centre of community life. A new generation of membership organisations should be part of the democratic mix in Scotland. A sense of 'belonging' to a sports club is often a critical factor in continuing to engage in sport throughout life.

In Norway, sport is one of the most powerful social and community movements. The national sport federation has almost two million memberships which break down into regional federations and all the way down to local clubs. Importantly, all the clubs are founded on the same democratic tradition and young people are given a key role at every level.

I believe that we can learn a lot from an approach that actively encourages voluntary work and membership.

We must move to a culture of support for sports clubs. We will begin by **introducing 100 per cent mandatory rate relief for sports clubs** which are registered as community amateur sports clubs with the Inland Revenue.





However, we must do more by **changing the system of government support for sport to really benefit clubs**. Local authorities will be assessed on how they support sports clubs, rather than just how they provide facilities. In fact I want to see more councils handing over facilities to communities and focusing on a new role as enablers of club sports.

The sports clubs of the future must become extended sporting families with mixed sex, age and sports teams. Some will provide a variety of sporting and other opportunities within one club. That is a challenging agenda for sport in Scotland, but I believe it is the right way forward.

I want to see sports clubs getting far more involved with promoting sport and physical activity to children and young people. **Schools must become community hubs allowing local sports clubs affordable access to excellent facilities**. We will work towards every school having a dedicated physical multi-use activity space.

We will **cut the cost of access to sport and leisure facilities to help encourage more young people to use the facilities on offer**, with funding to support local schemes, particularly during school holidays.

We will also fund two new Olympic size **swimming pools** in Aberdeen and Inverness and support the redevelopment of the Royal Commonwealth Pool in Edinburgh.

I want to encourage more partnerships between schools and clubs with new incentives for clubs. We will get Scotland's sports clubs more involved with a **new fund to support local clubs who work with schools to meet our new target for physical activity of an hour a day for every child**. This funding will allow each Active School cluster to commission sports coaching from local clubs for during and after the school day.

We will **deliver 1,000 extra sports coaches in Scotland** including support for an extra 100 PE teachers and 100 professional coaches to work through our national sports organisations. It will also support, through Active School clusters, 800 FTE voluntary coaches



Sport, culture and tourism

Sport, culture and tourism priorities

- › **£102 million boost for grassroots sport.**
- › **Free the arts from excessive government interference.**
- › **Support for the Scottish Music Futures Fund.**
- › **Full implementation of the National Gaelic Plan.**
- › **Grow Scottish tourism by 50 per cent by 2015.**

delivered through local sports clubs. This will include a ring fenced fund to **meet the cost to individuals of gaining the new UK Coaching Certificate (UKCC)**. We will also support the development of a **Scottish Centre of Coaching Excellence** to support coach development, education and training and the roll out of the UKCC. We will also increase funding for sports facilities.

Taken together this package will **deliver £102 million of additional support over the spending review - representing the single largest boost to grassroots sport seen in Scotland for decades**. I believe it will lay the foundations for a bright future for Scottish sport.

Competition is good – whether competing in sports at school or competing for votes for government. It means people can be tested and have to work hard to succeed. I recently visited the Glasgow School of Sport where pupils get coaching from some of Scotland's leading champions and international coaches. I was struck by the enthusiasm of the pupils and the positive attitudes of the school community. For those who are engaged in organised sport, we need to do more to **bring back a competitive spirit in Scotland** with many more inter-school, regional and national competitions such as mini-olympics.

Arts and culture

I believe that the health and vitality of arts and cultural creation and performance in Scotland is closely connected to our sense of place and to our community values.

Artists must have the freedom to create, and the arts must be free from excessive government interference and bureaucracy. Liberal Democrats believe that where government should support culture is to help it grow and give as many people as possible the chance to enjoy it, both as audience and as artists.

I believe it is particularly important for young people to have more diverse opportunities. We want the kind of education system that goes beyond just academic subjects and gives children an experience of music, art and drama.

I am keen to develop a Scottish Youth Music and Dance Festival to showcase the national youth festivals in the summer.

To encourage more young people to pursue a career in Scotland's creative industries, I will roll out a **young creative apprenticeship** to give young people hands on experience of performing arts, film, theatre, visual arts, music and design. For those that want to make a career in the creative industries, getting real experience early on is vital.

Funding for culture has increased with Liberal Democrats in government. We will ensure there is sustainable, high level investment for the arts in Scotland. As part of this drive, we will seek agreement with local authorities to move towards a higher, guaranteed level of investment in the arts.

The creative industries are becoming a great Scottish strength. We must support their economic potential but also their grassroots creativity. This is particularly true of film and music. In establishing Creative Scotland we will **ensure that the good work of Scottish Screen is not lost**. We will give Creative Scotland more scope to build on the success of Scottish Screen.

The Scottish contemporary music industry is making its mark internationally and is an industry that deserves government backing. I am delighted to give our **support to the new Scottish Music Futures Fund** to support the music stars of tomorrow. We will work alongside Creative Scotland and industry representatives to support the industry to develop its strategy for contemporary music.

Creative Scotland must be a powerhouse for all the arts. As an agency managing and providing large sums of public money it must be accountable to government, but that does not mean government should dictate its every move. We will therefore **ensure that the legislation that creates the agency does not allow ministers to intervene in decisions that are essentially about artistic judgement**. Creative Scotland should advise the government on the future needs of the sector, not the other way around.



As part of our wider investment in community facilities, we will task Creative Scotland with **developing a network of cultural hubs in the community** to improve access to facilities.

We will **continue to support our National Companies through sustained direct Scottish Executive funding** to ensure they continue to flourish and bring work of an international standard to audiences at home and abroad. We will continue to support music tuition in schools by sustaining the current commitment that all **school children should have had access to one year's free music tuition by the time they reach P6.**

Digital broadcasting offers enormous potential for the development of local and mobile television broadcasting, wireless broadband and other technologies as a result of the frequencies being released from digital switchover. We will work to ensure that Scotland has its fair share of the benefits provided by this **'digital dividend'** and we will work with stakeholders to realise the potential of community media to bring communities together and share information.

Scotland's languages

We will create a sustainable future for Gaelic in Scotland through the **full implementation of the recently launched National Plan for Gaelic** which sets out a five year roadmap to take the language forward. We will also support the **establishment of the Gaelic digital television** channel due to be launched later in 2007. We want to see a growth in the use of Gaelic over the long term. That is why we must **improve the availability of Gaelic-medium pre-school, primary and secondary education.** We will also improve **support for projects that recognise the importance of Scots language.**

Tourism

Scottish Liberal Democrats recognise the importance of tourism to Scotland's economy and its potential for

significant growth. Tourism turnover in Scotland is already more than £4 billion every year. And with world tourism projected to grow by 4 per cent per annum over the next decade the opportunity is clear. **We want to support the industry to meet its ambitious target to grow Scottish tourism by 50 per cent by 2015.**

To reach this goal we must continue to improve the level of service and quality of experience that we offer to tourists. That means continuing to invest in skills and training, for example through **modern apprenticeships.** It also means playing to our strengths and developing our appeal in a number of niche markets.

We will ensure that the Enterprise Networks and VisitScotland support business to develop new visitor experiences and niche markets reflecting our strengths as a destination for golf, outdoor activities, landscape, culture and heritage.

To remain competitive, Scotland must be open for business 24/7. We will ensure that VisitScotland drives forward the use of e-commerce for sales and marketing with continued improvement to the national portal website. We will support small tourism businesses to develop their online operations.

To reduce the impact of seasonality, we want to see more use of **Destination Management Organisations** to help diversify the tourism offering and improve the spread of visitors throughout the year. Scotland also has a growing reputation as a venue for business tourism and conferencing which we must continue to build on.

And because it is important that growth in tourism is sustainable, we will support an **expansion of the Green Tourism Business Scheme** to reward those businesses that rise to the green tourism challenge.

As part of our efforts to promote, celebrate and enhance our culture and heritage and build on our reputation as an excellent tourism destination, we will continue to **promote measures to protect our historic environment,** carrying through on the recently published Scottish Historic Environment Policy guidance and completing an audit of our historic environment.



Governance

“The establishment of the Scottish Parliament was a great step forward for Scotland. We need to continue to improve our system of governance, delivering more powers for the Scottish Parliament, strengthening local government, and involving people in decision making.”

More powers for the Scottish Parliament

A growing number of people support more powers for the Scottish Parliament – many more than support independence. The report of **the Steel Commission, chaired by former Scottish Parliament Presiding Officer David Steel, is leading the agenda in Scotland.** It calls for a new settlement based on more powers for Scotland within the UK, rather than separatism and independence.

The Steel Commission is right to call for **a second constitutional convention to consider the best ways to devolve new powers, including taxation powers, to the Scottish Parliament.** We will establish this new convention to review the powers of the Scottish Parliament in the light of the experience of two full terms. The challenge is for all Scotland's political parties to learn the lesson of the first Convention and to join the new Convention in order to build a consensus on the way forward. Civic Scotland must also be closely involved.

In calling for more powers for the Scottish Parliament, we believe in working with the UK Government. The Steel Commission recommended the **creation of a joint committee of the Scottish and UK Parliaments, and a new category of powers where the two parliaments should work in partnership.** The new Convention should consider the case for applying this approach in areas including regulatory powers, misuse and control of drugs, control of firearms, asylum and

immigration, strategic planning of welfare services, and aspects of employment law.

We believe that the Scottish Parliament should have exclusive competence over the electoral system, the operation of the Scottish Parliament itself, the civil service, energy policy, transport powers and marine policy.

The new Convention should also consider the case for extending the Scottish Parliament's powers over betting and gaming, public and bank holidays, human rights and equalities, and an increased role in governance of broadcasting.

I want to see a **new system of fiscal federalism** to increase significantly the taxation powers of the Scottish Parliament in order to improve accountability; increase transparency; encourage more efficient allocation of resources; and allow the Scottish Parliament to have its hands on the fiscal levers necessary to influence the direction of the Scottish economy. This is an important agenda for discussion during the term of the next Scottish Parliament.

The future of governance in Scotland

I believe that the time is right to reconsider the division of power in this country. Liberal Democrats believe in strong local government. That means redefining the relationship between the Scottish Parliament and local authorities to one based on mutual respect. This relationship should be backed by the principle that each level of government

should raise as much as practical of its own spending itself.

I believe it is time to grasp the nettle of the relationship between central and local government. We will **establish a Governance of Scotland Commission** to undertake a comprehensive examination of the structure and operation of the whole public sector, including the quango state.

I will ask it to make clear recommendations on what powers are most appropriately held by local councils, central government and government agencies and to consider the case for a **Governance of Scotland Bill** specifically to reserve powers to Scottish Ministers and devolve all others to local government, thereby entrenching the rights of local government.

To bring about more democratic accountability in decision making, we want to see a much greater scrutiny role for local government over health services in their area, with local scrutiny panels. The Governance Commission should also consider whether local government should take on more formal powers over primary health care in the future.

Passing new powers to local authorities from central government and the quango state must be matched by local authorities passing responsibility down still further to local people. We outline our proposals to empower local communities in the Communities section of this manifesto.

Scottish Liberal Democrats led the way in introducing a public sector relocation policy to Scotland to spread the benefits of government jobs to all parts of the country, particularly rural Scotland. The policy has delivered, but it



Governance priorities

- › **More powers for the Scottish Parliament.**
- › **New models of engagement with the public.**
- › **Governance of Scotland Commission to consider the division of power between central and local government.**
- › **Second Constitutional Convention to build consensus on new legislative and fiscal powers for the Scottish Parliament.**

is now time to refocus its objectives by introducing specific targeting of geographical areas, linked to regional development policy.

The head of an independent prosecution service should not also hold the role as chief legal advisor to the Cabinet. Therefore we will **review the role of the Lord Advocate with a view to separating these two responsibilities.**

Reforming local government

The introduction of proportional representation to local government is a major step forward and will lead to further reform and new ways of working in councils across Scotland.

We must not impose a one size fits all policy on local government or communities. I want to encourage innovation, not stifle it. That's why I will oppose central diktats and instead **allow councils to draw up their own internal structures.** Rather than impose a limited number of models from the centre, councils should be free to decide how they want to organise themselves, as long as the principles of openness, accountability and transparency are achieved.

Arbitrary lines drawn on maps don't deliver better services and neither should they decide the fate of democratically elected councils. I want to see more councils working together to improve back office functions, learn best practice, and enjoy economies of scale. More joint working between authorities can be delivered without forced amalgamations or centralisation. There may be areas where councils wish to come together and where there is a sensible case for doing so, we will work with authorities to facilitate that change. Our plans for councils to devolve more decision making down to communities will allow local scrutiny over service delivery.

Where there is a local demand, we will **pilot the development of single public bodies in each of the Island authority areas** to deliver more efficient public services. We will evaluate the results to learn lessons for the rest of Scotland.

Scotland's place in Europe

Scottish Liberal Democrats want to continue to build on Scotland's role in Europe. We want to see greater Scottish involvement in the development of European policy, regulations and legislation at the earliest possible stage. Where it is appropriate Scottish Ministers should lead UK delegations at EU Council meetings, as Scottish Liberal Democrat Ministers have already done.

Rethinking democracy

I want to see new, innovative ways of involving people in decision making. In an audit of political engagement by the Electoral Commission last year, 75 per cent of people said they wanted a say in how the country is run. Yet only around half say they will vote.

The recent report of the Power Inquiry gave us all food for thought. We must find new ways of engaging with those we represent, especially young people. It was clear from the report that people still want to be involved in the democratic process, but they want much more from their democracy and from their governments. People still care but don't connect. This is a challenge to government everywhere and I want Scotland to lead the way in meeting this new democratic demand.

There is too much tick box consultation on too few genuine options. I want to see the **government consultation process reformed**, government to go to people and engage with them, particularly with those who will be most affected.

The Power Inquiry recommended the introduction of open budget meetings to increase significantly public understanding and involvement in local budget decisions. I believe this is the sort of model that we should pilot in Scotland and that it can make a real difference to public engagement. I also want to see local authorities take up this challenge to give citizens more of a role in deciding on public services. This is just one step in **placing a duty on all public bodies to ensure genuine public involvement rather than simply consultation.**



This is the Scottish Liberal Democrat Manifesto for the 2007 Scottish Parliament election. It contains our priorities for government. A full costing of this programme for government will be published in a separate document.